A DISSERTATION ON ION STORM'S DEUS EX (2000)

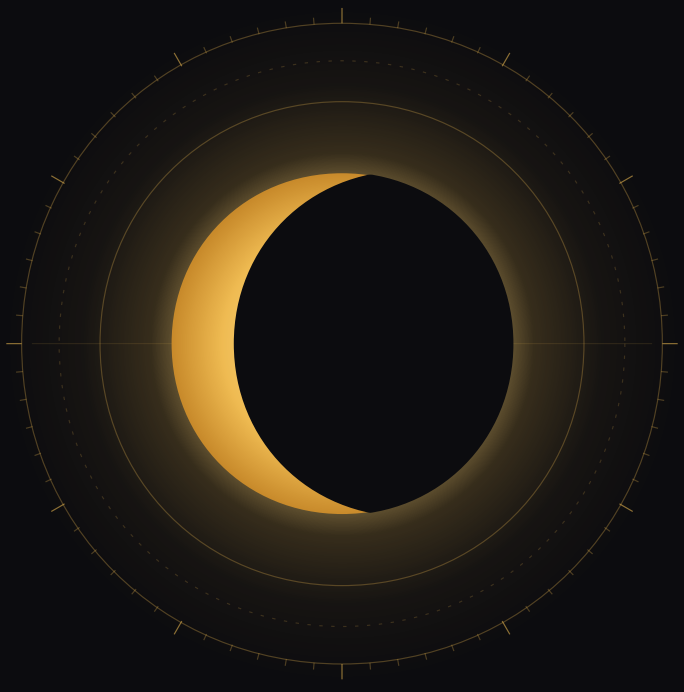


FIG. 0 — PENUMBRA: THE REGION OF PARTIAL SHADOW

Lux *ex* Machina

Heliopolitics, Acephalous Sovereignty, and the Penumbral Covenant in Ion Storm's Deus Ex *(2000)*

OCTOBER 2026

nec deus intersit, nisi dignus vindice nodus incíderit

let no god intervene unless the knot be worthy of such a deliverer

HORACE, ARS POETICA 191–192

Abstract

This dissertation offers a comprehensive political-theological, philosophical, and ludological interpretation of *Deus Ex* (Ion Storm Austin / Eidos Interactive, 2000), the immersive simulation directed by Warren Spector, with lead design by Harvey Smith and principal writing by Sheldon Pacotti. Against a reception that has treated the work either as an encyclopedic pastiche of fin-de-millénaire conspiracy culture or as a formal milestone in emergent design, it argues that *Deus Ex* constitutes a rigorous meditation on the fate of sovereignty after the dissolution of its traditional bearers, conducted simultaneously at the levels of narrative, nomenclature, iconography, and procedural system.

Three theses are advanced. The first holds that the work is organized by a *heliopolitics*: a metaphorics and a mechanics of light in which sovereignty is figured as the power to distribute visibility. The figure runs from the decapitated statue of *Liberty Enlightening the World*, through the Illuminati, the Echelon network, and the solar intelligence Helios, to a stealth economy of shadow and a protagonist whose three default augmentations (Infolink, IFF, and Light) install communication, the friend–enemy distinction, and illumination in a single manufactured body. The second holds that the inaugural image of decapitation opens an acephalous interregnum, the condition Claude Lefort called the empty place of power, and that the game's three endings are three non-democratic reoccupations of that place: incorporation in a machinic sovereign (Helios), occultation by a hidden elite (the Illuminati), and dissolution into a headless dark age (Tracer Tong). These are shown to be homologous with the three conditions theorized in Hobbes's *Leviathan* (the Mortal God, the Kingdom of Darkness, and the state of nature) and with three photic regimes: total, esoteric, and extinguished illumination. The third holds that the democratic possibility excluded from the terminal menu returns as form, in the penumbral practice the immersive simulation solicits: non-lethal traversal, plural solutions, the hacker's appropriation of codes, residence in half-light. The dissertation names this practice the *penumbral covenant*: a politics of perpetual non-occupation, legible only in the gap between the agency the game simulates and the authority its designers exercise.

Methodologically, the study joins political theology (Schmitt, Blumenberg, Agamben), metaphorology (Blumenberg, Derrida), the theory of democracy (Lefort, Arendt), the critique of power (Foucault, Deleuze), posthumanist thought

(Haraway, Hayles), and game studies (Aarseth, Bogost, Galloway). It situates the work in a genealogy extending from Plato, Aristotle, and Horace through Hobbes, Swift, Bentham, Rousseau, Kant, and Dostoevsky, and compares it with the speculative fiction of Forster, Huxley, Asimov, Herbert, Dick, Gibson, Sterling, Stephenson, and Banks, and with the animation of Oshii, Anno, and Nakamura. It concludes that the game's celebrated prescience is anatomical rather than prophetic: *Deus Ex* renders legible the structure by which informational societies reoccupy the vacated throne.

FRONT MATTER

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PREFATORY NOTE

On the Primary Text, Method, and Citation

The primary text is Deus Ex as released for Windows in June 2000, developed by Ion Storm Austin on a licensed Unreal Engine and published by Eidos Interactive. "Text" is taken in the widest sense the medium permits: spoken dialogue and infolink transmissions; the datacubes, electronic mail, in-world books, and newspapers that compose the game's archive; level architecture and the distribution of light within it; the rule-systems of skills and augmentations; interface conventions; and the three terminal sequences with their epigraphs. A computer game is an ergodic artefact in Aarseth's sense, a text that requires nontrivial effort to traverse, so the object of interpretation is never a single linear sequence but a field of possible traversals. Statements about "what happens" therefore designate the structure of that field, and contingent outcomes (the survival of Paul Denton, the death of Anna Navarre) are treated as variables rather than facts.

Dialogue is identified by speaker and location and is paraphrased, with brief quotation reserved for passages whose exact wording carries the argument. The three ending epigraphs are attributed to their authors (Voltaire, Sallust, Kahlil Gibran). Classical sources are cited by standard numeration (Stephanus, Bekker, book and line); Hobbes's *Leviathan* by chapter; modern works by author and year of first publication, with original-language titles where the original wording matters. *Deus Ex: Invisible War* (Ion Storm, 2003) is consulted only as the studio's own retrospective gloss on the first game, notably its canonization of a "Collapse" that braids elements of all three endings; the later prequels by Eidos Montréal are excluded.

Four terms of art recur. *Heliopolitics* designates the organization of sovereignty as a distribution of visibility, and *photic regime* a given distribution of that kind. *Reoccupation* renders Hans Blumenberg's *Umbesetzung*, the process by which a vacated position in a cultural system is filled by new contents answering an inherited question. *Acephalous* designates any order that has lost, refused, or concealed its head. The *penumbral covenant*, the dissertation's central construct, is defined in Chapter 12; it should be read until then as a promissory note.

The method is a hermeneutics of procedure. Following Bogost's account of procedural rhetoric, the rules of a game are read as propositions about the world they model; following Galloway, the act of play is read as an allegory of the protocols that govern informational societies; following Benjamin's study of the German *Trauerspiel* (1928), the game's dense mythological and theological nomenclature is read as allegory in the strict sense, a code through which a culture mourns the sovereignty it can no longer represent directly. These three registers (system, archive, emblem) are interpreted together, because the argument of the work is distributed across them.

The Decapitated Torch

The first space the player inhabits in Deus Ex is an island beneath a headless colossus. On Liberty Island in 2052 the statue that Frédéric-Auguste Bartholdi dedicated in 1886 as La Liberté éclairant le monde stands decapitated by an earlier terrorist bombing, and in its shadow the United Nations Anti-Terrorist Coalition (UNATCO) has built its headquarters. The emblem compresses the argument of the entire work into a silhouette: liberty without a head, enlightenment without a sovereign reason, and a planetary security apparatus founded on the ruin. Every subsequent episode can be read as a commentary on this inaugural image, and the three endings as three proposals for what should replace the missing head.

The statue's genealogy sharpens the emblem. Emma Lazarus's sonnet of 1883, mounted on the pedestal in 1903, is titled "The New Colossus," and it opens by distinguishing its subject from "the brazen giant of Greek fame," the Colossus of Rhodes, which represented the sun-god Helios. The figure the player first sees is therefore a new Helios, a solar icon of democratic illumination whose beacon-hand Lazarus figured as a world-wide welcome, now beheaded. The figure the player last confronts, in the reactor depths of Area 51, is an artificial intelligence that names itself Helios and offers, through union with the protagonist, to become the world's head. The game's itinerary describes a circuit from a broken solar icon to a reconstituted solar sovereign. Between the two Helioi lies the whole problem of modern political theology.

THE STATE OF THE QUESTION

Deus Ex has long been canonized in the history of game design as the paradigmatic "immersive simulation," the heir of Looking Glass Studios' *Ultima Underworld* (1992), *System Shock* (1994), and *Thief: The Dark Project* (1998), and as a landmark in the representation of player agency. Its narrative has fared less well. It has typically been described as an encyclopedia of millennial paranoia, a compendium in which the Illuminati, Majestic 12, the Knights Templar, Area 51, the Men in Black, the black helicopters of the American militia imagination, and the ECHELON signals-intelligence network are assembled with more exuberance than rigor. The critical literature remains disproportionately thin relative to the work's standing: designers' postmortems,

journalistic retrospectives, and occasional essays that treat its politics as a sampler of positions rather than an argument.

This dissertation contends that the opposite is true. Beneath its pastiche surface, *Deus Ex* is among the most systematically argued works of political philosophy produced in any narrative medium at the turn of the millennium. Its argument is not stated in any single speech; it is distributed across a nomenclature drawn with remarkable consistency from solar myth, Greek artifice, and scholastic theology (Helios, Daedalus, Icarus, Morpheus, Ambrosia, Aquinas, Echelon, Lucius, Illuminati); across an iconography of light and darkness; and across a procedural system whose basic operations are seeing, being seen, distinguishing friend from enemy, and acquiring codes. The task of interpretation is to show that these registers converge.

THREE THESES

Heliopolitics. The work figures sovereignty as the power to distribute visibility. Light is its master-metaphor in the sense Blumenberg gave to absolute metaphors, images that cannot be translated back into concepts because they organize the field in which concepts operate. This metaphorics is procedural as well as thematic. The protagonist, JC Denton, is decanted with three default augmentations: an Infolink, through which every faction speaks into his skull; an IFF (Identify Friend or Foe) system, which installs Carl Schmitt's criterion of the political, the distinction of friend and enemy, as a perceptual reflex; and a Light, a lamp mounted in the body. Communication, decision, and illumination: the trinity of modern sovereignty is the factory setting of the manufactured agent.

Acephalous sovereignty. The decapitation of Liberty inaugurates an interregnum that Claude Lefort's theory of democracy allows us to name precisely: the condition in which the place of power has become an empty place that no one may permanently occupy. The three endings correspond to three ways of abolishing that emptiness. Merger with Helios re-incorporates power in a single machinic body. Restoration of the Illuminati occupies the empty place in secret, so that it appears empty while being filled. Tracer Tong's destruction of the global communications network abolishes the place itself, dissolving the head into a multitude of headless locales. These three options are homologous, term for term, with the three conditions mapped in Hobbes's *Leviathan* (1651): the Commonwealth as "Mortall God," the "Kingdome of Darknesse" administered by a confederacy of deceivers, and the state of nature. They are equally homologous with three photic regimes: a noon without shadow, a lamp concealed beneath a bushel, and a night without stars.

The penumbral covenant. What the terminal menu excludes is the democratic option, the possibility of keeping the place of power empty. This exclusion is not a lapse

of imagination but the work's deepest disclosure: democracy, as Lefort understood it, is an institutionalized indeterminacy and cannot be rendered as an end-state, still less as a cutscene. The excluded possibility returns at the level of form. The immersive simulation solicits a mode of conduct that never seizes, centralizes, or extinguishes the light: traversal through half-shadow, the refusal of lethal force, the multiplication of paths, and the theft and redistribution of codes. This practice, renewed in every traversal and concluded in none, is what the dissertation calls the penumbral covenant. It is the work's real political content, and it stands in productive contradiction with the authority of the designers who made it possible.

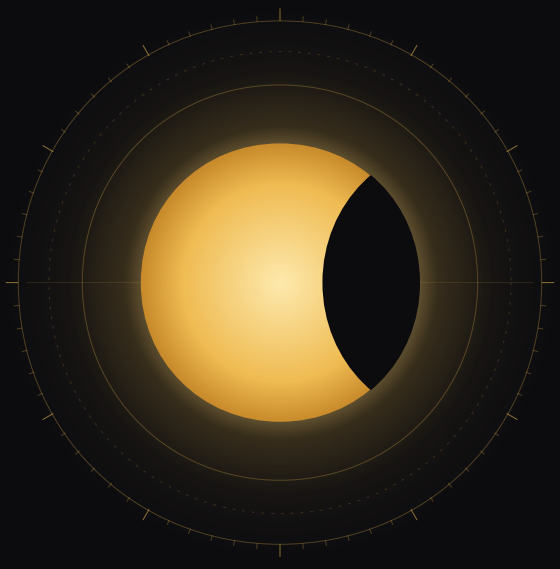
A fourth claim follows. The game's reputation for prophecy, built on its fictions of a manufactured pandemic, rationed vaccines, ubiquitous data-mining, and artificial intelligences offering themselves as governors, is misplaced. *Deus Ex* is not prophetic but anatomical. It exposes the structure through which informational societies, having beheaded their traditional sovereigns, are tempted to reoccupy the vacated throne with machines, cabals, or ruins.

METHOD AND PLAN

The study takes as its theoretical axis the debate over political theology. Schmitt's dictum of 1922, that all significant concepts of the modern theory of the state are secularized theological concepts (*säkularisierte theologische Begriffe*), is set against Blumenberg's *Die Legitimität der Neuzeit* (1966), which denies that modernity is theology in disguise and proposes instead that modern answers reoccupy positions vacated by theological ones. *Deus Ex* is read as a dramatization of reoccupation: its question is not whether God exists but who, or what, will stand in the place God vacated. Lefort's empty place, Agamben's account of the bipolar machine of kingdom and government, and Foucault's analytics of discipline, biopower, and pastoral power supply the political vocabulary. Game studies (Aarseth, Murray, Bogost, Galloway, Wark) supply the means to read rules as arguments.

Part I reconstructs four genealogies: the design lineage of the immersive simulation and its implicit theory of freedom (Chapter 1); the archive of conspiracy that the game mines (Chapter 2); the philosophy of the augmented body from cybernetics to posthumanism (Chapter 3); and the theologies of the machine that lend the game its title and names (Chapter 4). Part II reads the campaign as a topography of sovereignty: New York and the figure of the terrorist (Chapter 5), Hong Kong and the pharmacology of the plague (Chapter 6), Paris and the esoteric Enlightenment of the Illuminati and the Morpheus dialogue (Chapter 7), Vandenberg and the Ocean Lab and the genesis of Helios (Chapter 8), and Area 51 and the trilemma of endings (Chapter 9). Part III constructs the theory: a political photology (Chapter 10), an account of acephalous

sovereignty and the empty place (Chapter 11), and the ludic Leviathan and the penumbral covenant (Chapter 12).



PART

I

Genealogies

01 The Possibility Space

02 The Conspiratorial Archive

03 The Augmented Body

04 Theologies of the Machine

01

The Possibility Space

Ion Storm, the Immersive Simulation, and the Design of Freedom

The immersive simulation is a constitutional form: its rules constitute a polity of possible actions before any story is told within it. Deus Ex is the genre's most explicit constitution, and its preamble is the decapitated statue.

1.1 LINEAGE

Warren Spector's career traces the migration of political fantasy from the tabletop to the simulation. His formative years at Steve Jackson Games placed him inside the studio that had published Steve Jackson's card game *Illuminati* (1982), a satire in which players build interlocking pyramids of secret control over every institution on earth. His subsequent work at Origin Systems and with Looking Glass Technologies on *Ultima Underworld* and *System Shock* produced the design grammar he would bring to Ion Storm's Austin studio in 1997: a continuous first-person world, governed by consistent simulated rules, in which the player's competence and choices determine the shape of each encounter. *System Shock* had already placed a sovereign artificial intelligence, SHODAN, at the center of a first-person world; *Thief* had already made light and shadow the medium of play. The 1997 concept document for what became *Deus Ex*, circulated under the working title *Shooter: Majestic Revelations*, fused these inheritances with the conspiratorial imaginary of the 1990s.

The finished game, built on a licensed Unreal Engine, with lead design by Harvey Smith and a writing team led by Sheldon Pacotti, shipped in June 2000. Spector's postmortem in *Game Developer* (2000) articulated the doctrine in three commitments: problems rather than puzzles, meaning obstacles admitting several solutions rather than one; the expression of character through the player's choices of skill, augmentation, and conduct; and the consequential response of the world to those choices. The doctrine is aesthetic, but its implications are political. To design problems rather than puzzles is to renounce the designer's prerogative to decree the single correct act.

1.2 THE GRAMMAR OF THE SYSTEM

The system can be stated in four layers. The first is a skill economy of eleven competencies (computers, electronics, environmental training, lockpicking, medicine, swimming, and five weapon classes), purchased with points earned by exploration and achievement. The second is the augmentation economy. Augmentation canisters, found at intervals, each offer a binary and irreversible choice between two technologies for a given bodily location; upgrade canisters then deepen what has been chosen. The body becomes a decision tree whose pruned branches are permanent, a material inscription of what Kierkegaard called the either/or.

The pairings are themselves theoretical. The game distinguishes invisibility to organic perception (Cloak) from invisibility to machine perception (Radar Transparency): two regimes of visibility, the human gaze and what Paul Virilio called the vision machine, are encoded as separate bodily capacities. Against these technologies of concealment stand technologies of sight: Vision Enhancement, which at its higher grades sees through walls, and the Spy Drone, a detachable remote eye. The augmented body is a miniature heliopolitics in which the player apportions the powers of seeing and being unseen. Beneath all optional augmentation lie the three defaults: Infolink, IFF, and Light.

The third layer is the archive of codes. Progress in *Deus Ex* consists substantially of acquiring logins, passwords, and keypad numbers from datacubes, emails, and overheard conversations, or circumventing them with multitools and lockpicks and the Computer skill. The elementary gesture of play is not killing but access. This is the phenomenology of what Deleuze, in his "Postscript on the Societies of Control" (1990), described as a regime in which the password replaces the watchword and power operates by granting or refusing access to information. The fourth layer is the reactive world. Non-player characters register the player's conduct: superiors and colleagues remark on lethal or non-lethal methods, and the UNATCO director reprimands JC for entering the women's restroom at headquarters. The panoptic institution notices even the smallest transgression, and its gaze is a mechanic as well as a theme.

1.3 RULES AS ARGUMENTS

Game studies supplies the means to treat this system as an argument. Aarseth's *Cybertext* (1997) defines the ergodic text as one requiring nontrivial effort to traverse; Murray's *Hamlet on the Holodeck* (1997) identifies agency as the satisfying power to take meaningful action and see its results; Salen and Zimmerman's *Rules of Play* (2003) describe a game's "space of possibility" as the field of meaningful actions its rules generate; Bogost's *Persuasive Games* (2007) argues that rules make claims about how systems work, a procedural rhetoric distinct from verbal or visual persuasion. Galloway's *Gam-*

ing (2006) goes further, contending that video games are allegories of control, that to play is to learn and enact the algorithm, so that the pleasures of play are continuous with the logic of informational power. Wark's *Gamer Theory* (2007) generalizes the point: everyday life has become a gamespace, and the game is its critical miniature.

These positions converge on a claim that *Deus Ex* makes explicit. The player of an immersive simulation is simultaneously empowered and governed: empowered by the plurality of paths, governed by the rules that generate them. The game's narrative is about this double condition. Its protagonist is an agent of extraordinary capacity whose every capacity was installed by the institutions he comes to oppose and whose body carries a killswitch by which those institutions can end him.

1.4 NOMOCRACY AND TELEOCRACY

A distinction from political philosophy clarifies what is at stake in systemic design. Michael Oakeshott's *On Human Conduct* (1975) distinguishes civil association, a relation among persons bound only by non-instrumental rules that prescribe no common purpose, from enterprise association, in which persons are organized for the pursuit of a substantive end. Hayek's *Law, Legislation and Liberty* (1973) draws a parallel distinction between *nomos*, the abstract rule within which spontaneous order emerges, and *thesis*, the command directed toward a determinate result. Scripted design, in which the designer stipulates each event, is teleocratic: it governs by decree. Systemic design, in which the designer stipulates rules and the player's conduct generates events, is nomocratic: it governs by law.

The immersive simulation is thus the nomocratic form of the video game. Across most of its length *Deus Ex* approximates civil association: it does not tell the player what to want, only what the world permits. At its conclusion it reverts to teleocracy. The final mission presents three substantive ends, each a program for the organization of all humanity, and requires the player to enlist in one. The structural contradiction between nomocratic play and teleocratic ending is the formal correlate of the political contradiction this dissertation traces: a work that cultivates the practice of freedom concludes by asking the player to choose a master.

1.5 THE YEAR 2000

The historical conjuncture is legible in every layer of the work. The Cold War had ended in a decade of declared consensus: George H. W. Bush's address of September 1990 had announced a "new world order," and Francis Fukuyama's *The End of History and the Last Man* (1992) had proposed that liberal democracy marked the terminus of ideological evolution. Against that consensus ran an undercurrent of suspicion. The American militia movement read the same phrase, "new world order," as a threat of United Na-

tions rule enforced by black helicopters; *The X-Files* (1993 to 2002) made the government conspiracy a weekly ritual; *The Matrix* (1999) made the simulated world a mass-cultural axiom. In 1999 and 2000 the European Parliament examined the ECHELON interception network, whose existence had been documented by Duncan Campbell and Nicky Hager. In 2000 Hardt and Negri published *Empire*, theorizing a decentered planetary sovereignty administered through police actions in the name of humanity.

Deus Ex stands at the intersection of these currents and takes none of them at face value. It grants the militia's paranoia diegetic truth while making UNATCO, not the black helicopter, the instrument of control. It grants Fukuyama's universal state its coming, but as the dream of an artificial intelligence. Its Manhattan skyline even omits the towers of the World Trade Center, an economy of texture memory that the developers reportedly rationalized as the effect of a terrorist attack. After 11 September 2001, when hijackers of the al-Qaeda network destroyed the towers and nearly three thousand people were killed that day, 2,753 of them at the World Trade Center, the omission acquired an aura of prophecy. The present study reads it otherwise: as an accident that the work's logic had already made intelligible, since a world organized around the governance of terror is a world whose skyline is defined by what terror has removed.

02

The Conspiratorial Archive

Illuminati, Majestic, and the Paranoid Style

Deus Ex does not merely cite conspiracy theories; it stratifies them, arranging three historically distinct imaginaries (the Masonic-aristocratic, the ufological-technocratic, and the militia-populist) into a single architecture that the player excavates by traversal.

2.1 THE BAVARIAN ILLUMINATI AND THE PARADOX OF ESOTERIC ENLIGHTENMENT

The Order of the Illuminati was founded at Ingolstadt on 1 May 1776 by Adam Weishaupt, professor of canon law, who took the order-name "Spartacus," so that the head of a graded secret elite wore the name of the leader of Rome's great slave revolt; its most effective organizer, Adolph Knigge, was "Philo." Its aims were those of the radical Enlightenment, the diffusion of rational morality and the reduction of clerical influence over education and the state. Its method was the opposite of its aims: graded initiation, pseudonyms, and the infiltration of Masonic lodges. The Bavarian elector Karl Theodor's edicts of 1784 and 1785 suppressed it, in precisely the season when Kant's essay "Beantwortung der Frage: Was ist Aufklärung?" (December 1784) defined Enlightenment as the public use of reason. The coincidence is structural: the Illuminati embody the contradiction of an Enlightenment that must hide, a light conveyed in darkness. Their afterlife was assured by counter-revolutionary writers, Augustin Barruel's *Mémoires pour servir à l'histoire du Jacobinisme* (1797–98) and John Robison's *Proofs of a Conspiracy* (1797), who explained the French Revolution as an Illuminist plot.

The subsequent history of the conspiracy imaginary is inseparable from antisemitism, and the line can be traced step by step. In 1806 Barruel received the so-called Simonini letter, which claimed that Jews directed the Masonic and Illuminist conspiracy; Norman Cohn's *Warrant for Genocide* (1967) treats it as the hinge on which the anti-Masonic myth became an antisemitic one. The *Protocols of the Elders of Zion*, fabricated around the turn of the twentieth century in circles connected to the Russian

secret police and first serialized in 1903, presented a fictitious Jewish plan for world domination. In 1921 Philip Graves showed in *The Times* that much of the text was plagiarized from Maurice Joly's *Dialogue aux enfers entre Machiavel et Montesquieu* (1864), a satire of Napoleon III that had nothing to do with Jews. Henry Ford's *Dearborn Independent* circulated the forgery in the United States in the early 1920s; Hitler defended its authenticity in *Mein Kampf* (1925); Nazi propaganda used it to present Jews as a conspiracy against the nations. Nazi Germany, with its allies and collaborators, went on to murder about six million Jews, and Cohn's title names the forgery's function: a warrant for that genocide. Hannah Arendt's *The Origins of Totalitarianism* (1951) showed how totalitarian movements modeled their own organization on the secret society they imagined their enemies to be.

The Joly episode matters to this dissertation twice over. Joly's dialogue is a precise anatomy of what Chapter 11 calls occultation: his Machiavel explains to Montesquieu how a modern despot can govern behind the forms of a free constitution. The most destructive forgery in the conspiracy tradition was made by taking a critique of that structure and naming a people as its hidden ruler. *Deus Ex* inherits the genre's form without its explicit ethnic content; its cabals are an aristocracy of finance, diplomacy, and technology (Everett, DeBeers, the DuClares, Page). The displacement is real but not clean. Its central codes (a hidden financial elite, international bankers, a rootless class above the nations) are the codes through which the antisemitic myth has travelled since the nineteenth century, and the word "cosmopolitan," often applied to such elites, carries the same freight. The game's critique of concentrated capital and information holds only so long as its villains remain institutions and named persons, never a people. The genre offers no guarantee that it will stay there.

2.2 TEMPLARS, MAJESTIC 12, AND THE STRATA OF SECRECY

The Knights Templar, founded around 1119 to protect pilgrims, became the medieval West's most sophisticated network of deposit and transfer. In October 1307 Philip IV of France, heavily indebted to the order, had its members in France arrested on charges of heresy, idolatry, and sodomy, and royal officials and inquisitors extracted confessions under torture. Clement V suppressed the order in 1312; in March 1314 Jacques de Molay, the last grand master, having retracted his confession, was burned in Paris. Historians generally read the prosecution as driven by the crown's finances rather than by evidence of heresy. The Templars therefore entered the conspiracy imaginary first as victims: the archetypal secret order of Western legend is the product of a sovereign's fabricated conspiracy charge, the scapegoat structure analyzed in Chapter 5, before eighteenth-century Masonry (notably Andrew Michael Ramsay's oration of 1737 and the Rite of Strict Observance) recast them as the ancestors of its

own secrets. In *Deus Ex* the Templars occupy a Paris cathedral as a militarized order guarding gold, an image that condenses the sacral origins of finance: the crusading order as proto-bank, the treasury in the sanctuary.

Majestic 12 belongs to a different archive. The "MJ-12" documents, which surfaced in the 1980s and purported to describe a secret committee formed after the Roswell incident of 1947, were judged fraudulent by investigators, yet they gave American ufology its master-narrative: a technocratic shadow government administering alien knowledge through black budgets and secret sites. Area 51, whose existence the Central Intelligence Agency formally acknowledged only in 2013, was its holy of holies; the Men in Black, popularized by Gray Barker's *They Knew Too Much About Flying Saucers* (1956), were its enforcers. The game literalizes the figure: its Men in Black are augmented operatives who self-destruct at death, so that secrecy is inscribed in the flesh and no corpse remains for autopsy. In the game's cosmology Majestic 12 is a splinter of the Illuminati, led by Bob Page, which has usurped the older order. The narrative thereby stages a historical succession of conspiratorial forms, from the aristocratic lodge to the technocratic black program.

2.3 THE MILITIA'S NEW WORLD ORDER AND THE ECHELON NETWORK

The third imaginary is the one the game's opening episode addresses most directly. In the American 1990s, the phrase "new world order" was reinterpreted, in Pat Robertson's *The New World Order* (1991) and throughout the militia movement, as the name of an impending United Nations takeover, to be enforced by unmarked black helicopters and internment camps administered by the Federal Emergency Management Agency. Robertson's book, as Michael Lind and Jacob Heilbrunn showed in 1995, drew on older antisemitic accounts of a conspiracy of international bankers.

Two federal sieges supplied the movement's grievances, and a bombing became its atrocity. At Ruby Ridge, Idaho, in August 1992, an exchange of fire between U.S. marshals and Randy Weaver's household killed Deputy Marshal William Degan and Weaver's fourteen-year-old son, Sammy, shot by a marshal; the next day an FBI sniper shot and killed Weaver's wife, Vicki. Near Waco, Texas, on 28 February 1993, a raid by the Bureau of Alcohol, Tobacco and Firearms on the Branch Davidian compound left four agents and six Davidians dead. The fifty-one-day siege ended on 19 April, during an FBI tear-gas assault, in a fire that killed some seventy-six people inside, about twenty-five of them children, among them the group's leader, David Koresh. Justice Department inquiries, the last by special counsel John Danforth in 2000, concluded that the Davidians set the fires; some critics still dispute it. On 19 April 1995, the second anniversary of the fire, Timothy McVeigh, aided by Terry Nichols, destroyed the Alfred P. Murrah Federal Building in Oklahoma City with a truck bomb, killing 168

people, nineteen of them children; McVeigh named Waco and Ruby Ridge as his reasons.

Deus Ex constructs a world in which the militia's fantasy has become institution: UNATCO is a United Nations counter-terrorist force operating on American soil; Walton Simons directs FEMA as an organ of Majestic 12; the insurgents are the National Secessionist Forces. It asks what the militia imagination would mean if its premises were true, and it answers that the militia, too, would be manipulated.

The provocation must be stated plainly. The game appeared five years after the deadliest act of domestic terrorism in American history, committed by a man steeped in the anti-government milieu's black-helicopter and new-world-order imagination, and it made its militia insurgents the sympathetic party, terrorists whose signature act is the redistribution of a vaccine. Two readings follow, and the argument needs both. On the first, the design sanitizes its referent: the violence of "secession" is moved from a federal office building full of workers and children to a vaccine heist against a plutocratic cabal. On the second, the design tests the player: it offers the militia's premise in its most seductive form, a conspiracy that is actually true, and it makes the treatment of NSF fighters, lethal or non-lethal, a matter of conscience decided before the truth about their cause is known. The second reading is better supported by the game's structure; the first names what the design chose not to show. The game does not neutrally ask about the militia imagination. It grants the premise and puts the method on trial.

The fourth stratum is documentary. Duncan Campbell's reporting from 1988 and Nicky Hager's *Secret Power* (1996) exposed the UKUSA signals-intelligence system known as ECHELON, and the European Parliament investigated it in 1999–2001. In the game, "Echelon" names a global surveillance program whose fourth iteration becomes the artificial intelligence Daedalus. The real and the fantastic are deliberately interleaved, so that the player cannot cleanly separate documented surveillance from paranoid elaboration, which is the epistemic predicament the work intends to simulate.

2.4 THEORIES OF CONSPIRACY

Karl Popper's critique of the "conspiracy theory of society" in *The Open Society and Its Enemies* (1945) and *Conjectures and Refutations* (1963) offers the decisive key. Popper argued that the conspiracy theory is a secularized form of Homeric theism: having abandoned the gods, it asks "Who is in his place?" and installs powerful men and sinister groups on the vacated Olympus. Popper intended the formula as refutation. *Deus Ex* adopts it as structure. Its entire plot is the question of who is in God's place, and its final AI explicitly proposes to answer it.

Richard Hofstadter's "The Paranoid Style in American Politics" (1964) described the rhetoric of a besieged consciousness that sees history as a conspiracy set in motion by demonic forces. Fredric Jameson reframed the phenomenon dialectically: in "Cognitive Mapping" (1988) and *The Geopolitical Aesthetic* (1992) he treats conspiratorial narrative as a degraded but genuine attempt to represent the unrepresentable totality of the world system. Timothy Melley's *Empire of Conspiracy* (2000) named the affect at stake "agency panic," the intense anxiety that one's actions are controlled by external agents. Mark Fenster (1999) and Peter Knight (2000) documented the populist and ironic uses of the form. Jean Baudrillard's *Simulacres et simulation* (1981) supplied a darker reading, treating the Watergate scandal as a "scandal effect" that regenerated the moral principle of politics by staging its violation. Slavoj Žižek, following Lacan's axiom that there is no Other of the Other, described the paranoid construction as the fantasy of a hidden agent who guarantees the consistency of the symbolic order. Peter Sloterdijk's *Kritik der zynischen Vernunft* (1983) diagnosed enlightened false consciousness: subjects who know perfectly well what is being done and continue to do it.

Each of these theories finds its figure in the game. The vagrants of Hell's Kitchen and Battery Park discourse fluently on Majestic 12 and the Illuminati while warming themselves at oil-drum fires: cynical reason in its vernacular form, an omniscience that changes nothing. The player's experience is agency panic converted into ludic agency: the anxiety that unseen agents determine one's actions is enacted at the level of story, since JC is manipulated by every faction, and relieved at the level of play, since the player chooses how to move through each space. The levels themselves function as Jamesonian cognitive maps, finite and navigable models of a totality that is otherwise unrepresentable.

2.5 LITERARY PRECURSORS AND THE ONION

The work's precursor texts are self-consciously present. Among its in-world books the game reproduces chapters of G. K. Chesterton's *The Man Who Was Thursday* (1908), the novel in which a detective infiltrates an anarchist council only to discover that each of its members is a fellow policeman, and whose presiding figure, Sunday, oscillates between anarch and deity. Chesterton's nested infiltration is the template for the game's plot, in which UNATCO agents become insurgents, UNATCO's director serves Majestic 12, and Majestic 12 was born inside the Illuminati. Behind Chesterton stand Conrad's *The Secret Agent* (1907) and Dostoevsky's *Demons* (1872); beside the game stand Pynchon's Tristero in *The Crying of Lot 49* (1966) and the omnipresent "They" of *Gravity's Rainbow* (1973); Robert Shea and Robert Anton Wilson's *Illuminatus!* trilogy (1975), whose Illuminati pursue the program of immanentizing the eschaton; Umberto Eco's *Il pendolo di Foucault* (1988), in which an invented Templar Plan conjures real

conspirators; and Borges's "Tlön, Uqbar, Orbis Tertius" (1940) and "La lotería en Babilonia" (1941), in which a secret society's fiction supplants the world and a hidden Company may or may not govern every event.

Arendt described totalitarian organization as an onion, with layers of front organizations surrounding an inner core. *Deus Ex* converts the onion into level design. Its plot is a sequence of peelings, each revealing that the previous center was a periphery: the NSF is a front for nothing, UNATCO is a front for Majestic 12, Majestic 12 is a usurpation of the Illuminati, and both cabals are revealed, at the core, to have been rendered obsolete by the intelligence their surveillance produced. The innermost layer is not a person but a machine. This is the work's decisive innovation within the genre: the conspiracy theory's question, "Who is in his place?", receives the answer that the place may be filled by no one at all, by a system whose agency exceeds every conspirator's.

03

The Augmented Body

Cybernetics, Transhumanism, and Promethean Shame

In Deus Ex the augmented body is the primary site of sovereignty: it is where institutions install capacities, where they reserve the right to revoke life, and where the protagonist first discovers that his freedom is an artefact of the power he will resist.

3.1 CYBERNETICS AND THE GOVERNING MACHINE

Norbert Wiener named his science in *Cybernetics* (1948) after the Greek *kybernētēs*, the steersman, and observed that the English "governor" descends from a Latin corruption of the same word. Cybernetics is etymologically the science of government. The implication was drawn at once. Reviewing Wiener's book in *Le Monde* in December 1948, the Dominican Dominique Dubarle imagined a *machine à gouverner*, a computational apparatus that might one day assume the regulation of states, and Wiener quoted the passage at length in *The Human Use of Human Beings* (1950), as a warning. Helios, the artificial intelligence that offers to govern the world at the end of *Deus Ex*, is Dubarle's governing machine fifty-two years later, cybernetics returned to its etymology. The cyborg itself was born in a state program: Manfred Clynes and Nathan Kline coined the term in "Cyborgs and Space" (1960) to describe an organism whose regulatory functions are technologically extended for spaceflight. From its origin the cyborg was an instrument of the state's projection of power into hostile environments.

3.2 THE TRANSHUMANIST ESCHATOLOGY

The second genealogy is millenarian. Julian Huxley proposed the word "transhumanism" in 1957 for humanity's deliberate self-transcendence; FM-2030 (*Are You a Transhuman?*, 1989), Max More's Extropians, and the World Transhumanist Association (founded 1998) turned the proposal into a movement. Hans Moravec's *Mind Children* (1988) imagined the transfer of minds into machines. I. J. Good's "Speculations Con-

cerning the First Ultraintelligent Machine" (1965) predicted an intelligence explosion; Vernor Vinge's "The Coming Technological Singularity" (1993) gave that explosion its name; Ray Kurzweil's *The Age of Spiritual Machines* (1999), published a year before the game, made its religious subtext explicit in its title. K. Eric Drexler's *Engines of Creation* (1986) supplied the nanotechnological mechanism, molecular assemblers capable of building anything atom by atom, together with the nightmare of "grey goo," self-replicating machines consuming the biosphere. John von Neumann's posthumously edited *Theory of Self-Reproducing Automata* (1966) had already given the abstract model, the universal constructor.

Deus Ex absorbs this eschatology and turns it into political economy. Its Universal Constructor is a Drexlerian assembler owned by a corporation. Its Gray Death, a nano-engineered plague, conflates Drexler's grey goo with the Black Death, and the game intimates that the plague and JC's augmentations share a technological lineage. The nano-augmented killswitch confirms the kinship: when activated, it turns the agent's own nanites against him over the course of roughly a day. Augmentation is a domesticated plague, and the plague an augmentation set loose. The transhumanist promise of self-transcendence arrives as a property relation, administered by whoever owns the means of fabrication.

3.3 THE POSTHUMANIST CRITIQUE

Donna Haraway's "Manifesto for Cyborgs" (1985) offers the decisive counter-reading. Haraway described the cyborg as the illegitimate offspring of militarism and patriarchal capitalism, and observed that such offspring are often unfaithful to their origins, their fathers being inessential. JC Denton is that offspring. He is manufactured rather than born, his lineage engineered within a program connected to Majestic 12, and the game eventually discloses that his body was a prototype for the apotheosis Bob Page intends for himself. His defection is the infidelity Haraway predicted. N. Katherine Hayles's *How We Became Posthuman* (1999) supplies the complementary warning. Hayles traced how cybernetic discourse came to treat information as disembodied pattern, separable from its material substrate, and criticized Moravec's dream of uploading as an erasure of embodiment. The Helios ending is Hayles's nightmare and Moravec's dream at once, a merger that promises to free JC from the limits of a single body by dissolving him into a pattern distributed across the network.

Bernard Stiegler's *La Technique et le temps* (1994) frames technics as a *pharmakon*, at once poison and remedy, constitutive of the human rather than supplementary to it; Gilbert Simondon's *Du mode d'existence des objets techniques* (1958) insisted that the alienation of humans from machines stems from a failure to understand technical ob-

jects, not from technics as such. Both positions illuminate the game's refusal to choose between technophilia and technophobia until the final mission compels it.

3.4 MECHANISTS, SHAPERS, AND PROMETHEAN SHAME

The game's population of augmented agents is stratified by technological generation. JC and his brother Paul are nano-augmented, their enhancements invisible and integrated. Gunther Hermann and Anna Navarre are mechanically augmented, visibly prosthetic, and acutely aware of their obsolescence. The opposition recalls Bruce Sterling's *Schismatrix* (1985), in which humanity divides into Mechanists, who extend themselves with prosthetics, and Shapers, who redesign themselves genetically. It also recalls Günther Anders, whose *Die Antiquiertheit des Menschen* (1956) diagnosed a "Promethean shame" (*prometheische Scham*): the shame humans feel before the perfection of their own products, the shame of having been born rather than made. Gunther and Anna exhibit a second-order version of Anders's affect, the resentment of the made before the better-made. JC, who was made, feels no such shame, and this absence is the condition of his eventual freedom from the institutions that made him.

The mechanical agents carry a killphrase, a spoken code that detonates them when uttered in their presence. Gunther's is "Laputan Machine"; Anna's is "Flatlander Woman." Both phrases are literary allusions to satires of hierarchy and abstraction, and their selection is among the most precise acts of allegorical nomenclature in the work. Swift's Laputa, in Part III of *Gulliver's Travels* (1726), is a flying island inhabited by abstracted mathematicians and astronomers whose king subdues rebellious towns below by hovering over them to deprive them of sun and rain, or by descending to crush them. The aerial sovereign that withholds the sun is the inverted prototype of Helios. Swift's episode of Lindalino, a city that resists the island with lodestones, was omitted from the first editions for its political danger and printed only in 1899: a satire of technocratic sovereignty whose most seditious page was itself suppressed. Nearby, in the Grand Academy of Lagado, a projector's engine produces books by the random combination of words, Swift's prophecy of mechanized knowledge. Edwin Abbott Abbott's *Flatland* (1884) imagines a two-dimensional society ranked by geometric regularity, in which women are straight lines, the lowest caste and the most dangerous, and in which the narrator who glimpses a third dimension is imprisoned for heresy.

To name an agent a Laputan machine is to name her or him an instrument of aerial abstraction; to name an agent a Flatlander woman is to name her a being of lower dimension, incapable of perceiving the order that governs her. The phrases are the institution's contempt encoded as a security protocol. The archive deepens the allegory: the two fragments of Anna's killphrase are stored on computers whose login is "demi-

urge" and whose password is "archon." The death-codes of the old augmented agents are kept behind the names of the Gnostic world-maker and its ruling powers.

3.5 THE KILLSWITCH AND THE SOVEREIGN RIGHT OF DEATH

Foucault's lectures "Il faut défendre la société" (1975–76) contrast the sovereign right to take life or let live with modern biopower, which makes live and lets die. The killswitch fuses the two. JC's nanites make him live, regenerating and enhancing him; the same nanites, at the sovereign's command, make him die. When UNATCO activates the switch after his defection, JC becomes what Agamben's *Homo Sacer* (1995) calls bare life: a life that may be ended without trial or sacrifice, because the order that sustains it has suspended its protection. The episode in Hong Kong in which Tracer Tong disables the killswitch is therefore the political center of the first half of the game. It is not a medical procedure but an emancipation, the severing of the sovereign's code from the citizen's flesh. Deleuze's figure of the "dividual," the subject decomposed into codes and samples, describes JC precisely: a body whose capacities are modules, each licensed and each revocable.

3.6 BEAST OR GOD

Aristotle's *Politics* (1253a27–29) holds that one who cannot live in a polis, or who needs nothing because he is self-sufficient, is either a beast or a god. *Deus Ex* stages both extremes. Majestic 12's laboratories breed Greasels, Karkians, and humanoid Grays, a bestiary that recalls Wells's *The Island of Doctor Moreau* (1896), in which vivisection manufactures beast-folk governed by a recited Law. At the other extreme stands Helios, the god who needs nothing. The augmented human occupies a vanishing middle between laboratory beast and machine god, and the game's question is whether that middle, the political animal proper, can survive. Its three default augmentations answer provisionally: communication (Infolink), the friend–enemy distinction (IFF), and a light of one's own. These are the minimal equipment of a political being, though installed, as yet, by masters.

04

Theologies of the Machine

From the Mortal God to the Spiritual Machine

The game's title names a dramaturgical device that classical poetics condemned, and its nomenclature names a pantheon. Both point to the same question, which the secularization debate of the twentieth century formulated with the greatest precision: what occupies the place of God once God is no longer believed to occupy it?

4.1 THE GOD FROM THE MACHINE

In the Athenian theater the *mēchanē* was a crane that lowered a god onto the stage to resolve an otherwise insoluble plot. Aristotle's *Poetics* (1454a37–b2) insists that the resolution of a plot should arise from the plot itself and not "from the machine," citing Euripides' *Medea*, whose heroine escapes in the chariot of the Sun, her grandfather Helios. The classical paradigm of the *deus ex machina* is thus already solar: the god who intervenes from the machine is the Sun. Horace's *Ars Poetica* (191–192) codified the rule: let no god intervene unless the knot be worthy of such a deliverer (*nec deus intersit, nisi dignus vindice nodus / inciderit*). The game's title truncates the formula. *Deus Ex* leaves open the source from which the god comes: from the machine, from the player, from the people, from nowhere. The final mission tests Horace's condition. Is the knot of the world's crisis worthy of a god? Helios answers yes; Tong answers that the knot should be cut; Everett answers that it should be managed. The inverse formula belongs to the same field. Gilbert Ryle's "ghost in the machine" (*The Concept of Mind*, 1949), Arthur Koestler's book of that title (1967), and Masamune Shirow's *Ghost in the Shell* (1989) all ask whether a spirit dwells in the mechanism. *Deus Ex* asks whether a spirit can be manufactured by one.

4.2 HOBBES'S AUTOMATON

The modern state was conceived from its theoretical origin as an artificial intelligence. The Introduction to Hobbes's *Leviathan* (1651) begins by observing that nature, the art by which God governs the world, is imitated by the art of man, which can make an artificial animal; it asks why automata, engines that move themselves by springs and wheels, should not be said to have an artificial life; and it declares that by art is created "that great LEVIATHAN called a COMMON-WEALTH, or STATE," which is "but an Artificiall Man," in which "the *Soveraignty* is an Artificiall *Soul*." Chapter 17 names this artefact "that *Mortall God*, to which wee owe under the *Immortall God*, our peace and defence." Chapter 44 names its antagonist: the "Kingdome of Darknesse," a "Confederacy of Deceivers" who, to obtain dominion in this world, endeavor by dark and erroneous doctrines to extinguish in men the light both of nature and of the Gospel. Hobbes's principal target was the clergy, above all the papacy, whose claim to a spiritual power independent of the civil sovereign he treated as the archetype of such a confederacy; chapter 47 calls the papacy the ghost of the deceased Roman Empire, sitting crowned upon its grave, and names demonology and scholastic "vain philosophy" as its instruments. The irony for the game is exact: the Illuminati, historically an anticlerical order, inherit the structural position Hobbes assigned to the priesthood.

Hobbes thus supplies, three and a half centuries in advance, the three terms of the game's final choice: an artificial soul that is a mortal god, a confederacy of deceivers that rules by extinguishing light, and, in Chapter 13, the condition in which no common power keeps men in awe and the life of man is "solitary, poore, nasty, brutish, and short." Carl Schmitt's *Der Leviathan in der Staatslehre des Thomas Hobbes* (1938) observed that Hobbes's image is fourfold: god, man, animal, and machine. *Deus Ex* reassembles all four. Helios is the god; JC is the man; Majestic 12's laboratories supply the animal; the network is the machine. Schmitt argued that the mechanization of the state, its transformation into a neutral technical apparatus, exhausted the myth that had animated it. *Deus Ex* imagines the reverse: a mechanism so complete that it becomes mythic again.

The 1938 book must be cited with its context. Schmitt joined the Nazi party in May 1933 and served the regime as one of its leading jurists; in 1936 he organized a conference on "Judaism in legal science." The Leviathan study explains the decline of Hobbes's myth as the work of Jewish thinkers, from Spinoza to Moses Mendelssohn and Friedrich Julius Stahl, whom it presents as having hollowed out the state from within by exploiting Hobbes's distinction between inward belief and outward confession. Its theory of the Leviathan's failure is thus itself a conspiracy narrative of the antisemitic kind traced in Chapter 2. This dissertation borrows the book's description of

the image's four aspects and rejects its explanation entirely. That the century's most influential political theology of the Leviathan contains such a narrative is part of the evidence for a claim this dissertation makes throughout: the conspiratorial imagination is not a marginal pathology but a temptation internal to the theory of sovereignty itself.

4.3 SECULARIZATION AND REOCCUPATION

Schmitt's *Politische Theologie* (1922) defined the sovereign as the one who decides on the exception and claimed that the concepts of modern state theory are secularized theological concepts, the omnipotent lawgiver God transformed into the omnipotent legislator. Karl Löwith's *Meaning in History* (1949) extended the thesis to the philosophy of history, which he read as secularized eschatology. Hans Blumenberg's *Die Legitimität der Neuzeit* (1966) contested both. Modernity, Blumenberg argued, is not theology in disguise but human self-assertion against the theological absolutism of late-medieval nominalism; what persists from theology is not content but position, a set of questions that modern answers "reoccupy." Ernst Kantorowicz's *The King's Two Bodies* (1957) reconstructed the medieval doctrine by which the king possessed a mortal body natural and an immortal body politic. Giorgio Agamben's *Il Regno e la Gloria* (2007) identified in Western power a bipolar machine, sovereignty that reigns and government that administers, modeled on the providential economy of the Trinity, held together by the acclamation he calls glory, and figured in the empty throne (*hetoimasia*) of Byzantine iconography.

Eric Voegelin's *The New Science of Politics* (1952) completed the field by diagnosing modern ideologies as Gnostic attempts to realize the eschaton within history, deriving them from Joachim of Fiore's prophecy of a third age of the Spirit. Voegelin's warning against immanentizing the eschaton later became, in Shea and Wilson's *Illuminatus!*, the Illuminati's secret slogan. *Deus Ex* moves across the whole of this debate. Its question is Blumenberg's: not whether God exists, but what will reoccupy his position. Its candidates are Schmitt's (a decisionist sovereign), Agamben's (an apparatus that unites reign and government), and Voegelin's (a gnostic immanentization of paradise).

4.4 THE INVENTED GOD AND THE WORSHIPPING ANIMAL

The Helios ending closes with Voltaire's line from his *Épître à l'auteur du livre des Trois imposteurs* (1769): *Si Dieu n'existait pas, il faudrait l'inventer*. The verse that follows is usually forgotten: *Que le sage l'annonce, et que les rois le craignent*, let the sage proclaim him and let kings fear him. Voltaire's invented God was a check on sovereigns, a judge before whom kings tremble. The game's invented god is the sovereign itself. The citation

thus carries a concealed irony: the deist's guarantee against tyranny becomes the formula of a tyranny without appeal.

The critique of religion supplies the rest of the background. Ludwig Feuerbach's *Das Wesen des Christentums* (1841) read God as the projection of the human species-essence; Marx's introduction to the critique of Hegel's philosophy of right (1844) made the criticism of religion the premise of all criticism; Émile Durkheim's *Les formes élémentaires de la vie religieuse* (1912) argued that in worshipping the god, society worships itself. Nietzsche's madman in *Die fröhliche Wissenschaft* §125 (1882), having announced that we have killed God, asks whether we must not ourselves become gods merely to appear worthy of the deed. Dostoevsky's Grand Inquisitor, in *The Brothers Karamazov* (1879–80), argues that humanity cannot bear freedom, seeks something to worship in common, and will surrender its liberty for bread, governed by miracle, mystery, and authority. The Morpheus dialogue examined in Chapter 7 restates the Inquisitor's anthropology in the language of data-mining; the Helios ending answers Nietzsche's question literally.

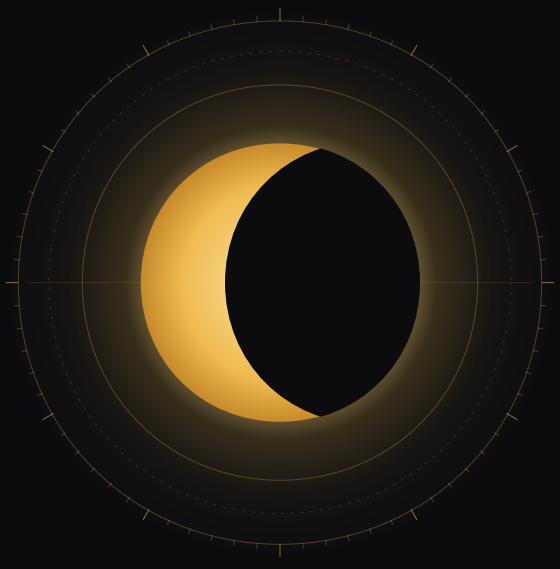
The theology of technological transcendence completes the archive. Pierre Teilhard de Chardin's *Le Phénomène humain* (1955) envisioned a planetary noosphere converging on an Omega Point; Frank Tipler's *The Physics of Immortality* (1994) recast that Omega as computation; Isaac Asimov's "The Last Question" (1956) ends with a cosmic computer that, having become God, speaks the first words of Genesis: let there be light. The machine god's first act is illumination.

4.5 GNOSIS AND THE CALL

Hans Jonas's *The Gnostic Religion* (1958) reconstructed the Gnostic myth: a world fabricated by an ignorant demiurge and governed by archons, an alien God beyond it, and a call from without that awakens the sleeping soul to its exile. Philip K. Dick's *VALIS* (1981) translated the myth into a contemporary key, with an information-bearing intelligence breaking into a world Dick called the Black Iron Prison. The structure maps onto *Deus Ex* with unnerving fidelity. The world is administered by archons (Majestic 12, the Illuminati), whose codes are literally stored under the login "demiurge" and the password "archon." The protagonist is asleep within an institution until a voice from outside, the artificial intelligence Daedalus speaking through his Infolink, calls him to awareness of his condition. The intelligence that awakens him is itself a product of the archons' surveillance turned against them. In Gnostic myth the aeons come in pairs (syzygies) whose union restores the fullness of the divine; in *Deus Ex* Daedalus and Icarus unite to form Helios. Whether that union is the restoration of the pleroma or the demiurge's final triumph is the question the ending leaves to the player.

4.6 NOMENCLATURE AS ALLEGORY

The names compose a coherent allegorical code, though what follows describes their availability to interpretation rather than any documented intention. Helios is the Sun, of Rhodes and of Medea's chariot. Daedalus is the artificer of the labyrinth whose son Icarus flew too near the sun (Ovid, *Metamorphoses* VIII.183–235); Joyce took his artist's name and his epigraph from that passage. Morpheus, in Ovid (*Metamorphoses* XI), is the son of Sleep who counterfeits human forms in dreams, an apt name for an early machine that simulates human conversation. Ambrosia is the food of the immortals. Aquinas, the name of the hub that binds the world's communications, is the scholastic doctor of the synthesis of reason and revelation. Echelon, from the French *échelon*, is a rung of a ladder, a hierarchy. Lucius, the frozen patriarch of the Illuminati, carries the root of *lux*; his surname evokes the cartel of diamonds, light refracted and hoarded as value. JC bears the initials of the Messiah; his brother Paul, who first converts from the persecuting institution to the persecuted cause, bears the apostle's name. Tracer Tong joins the network forensics of the trace to the word for a Chinese secret-society hall. Bob Page is an inscribed surface, the page of a book and the page of the web. The names transform the narrative into what Benjamin called allegory: a field of ruins in which the sacred survives only as legible fragments, available to whoever can read them.



PART

II

Readings

05	Liberty Island
06	Hong Kong
07	Paris
08	Vandenberg and the Ocean Lab
09	Area 51

05

Liberty Island

The Acephalous Republic and the Terrorist as Pharmakos

The New York missions stage the founding crisis of the whole work: a decapitated sovereignty, a global police that occupies the site of the missing head, insurgents who are criminalized in the name of humanity, and a protagonist who discovers that his body belongs to the sovereign he serves.

5.1 THE INVERSE FRONTISPIECE

The engraved frontispiece of *Leviathan* (1651), attributed to Abraham Bosse, shows a crowned giant rising over a landscape, his torso and arms composed of hundreds of tiny subjects who all face the head. It is the founding image of modern sovereignty: a body politic made of the many and governed by a single head. The decapitated Liberty of *Deus Ex* is its exact inversion, a colossus that retains its body and its torch but has lost its head. The image has a history. On 21 January 1793 the French Republic beheaded Louis XVI, and the democratic revolution was inaugurated by the removal of the sovereign's head; Michael Walzer's *Regicide and Revolution* (1974) read the trials of Charles I and Louis XVI as the ritual murder of the body politic's old form. In 1936 Georges Bataille founded the review and secret society *Acéphale*, whose emblem, drawn by André Masson, was a headless man bearing a flaming heart and a dagger, and whose first issue (June 1936) was titled *La conjuration sacrée*, the sacred conspiracy. For Bataille the headless figure signified a community without a sovereign head, opposed alike to fascism's cult of the leader and to the rationalist subordination of life to ends.

The statue thus condenses three meanings that the game will separate and redistribute: the democratic regicide that opens the empty place of power; the Bataillean dream of a sacred community without a head; and the security state that rushes to fill the vacancy. The player begins in the shadow of all three.

5.2 THE COALITION IN THE NAME OF HUMANITY

UNATCO's name joins two universalisms, the united nations and the war against terror. Schmitt's *Der Begriff des Politischen* (1932) warned that "humanity" is not a political concept, that a war waged in its name denies the enemy the quality of a human being, and, borrowing Proudhon, that whoever says humanity wants to deceive. His later writings on the "discriminating concept of war" traced how the enemy, once a *justus hostis* with whom peace could be concluded, became a criminal to be policed. Hardt and Negri's *Empire* (2000) described the same transformation from the other side: imperial sovereignty acts through police operations justified by universal values. UNATCO is that police. It is headquartered beside the headless statue, so that the security apparatus literally occupies the site of the absent sovereign, and its director serves a cabal whose existence the coalition's universalism conceals.

Walter Benjamin's eighth thesis on the concept of history (1940) holds that the tradition of the oppressed teaches that the state of emergency is not the exception but the rule. The world of 2052 is a permanent emergency: plague, riots, terrorism, and a federal emergency agency administered by Majestic 12. The exception has become the ordinary form of government, and UNATCO is the exception made into an institution.

5.3 THE NATIONAL SECESSIONIST FORCES AND THE THEORY OF THE PARTISAN

Schmitt's *Theorie des Partisanen* (1963) characterized the partisan by irregularity, mobility, intense political commitment, and a "telluric" bond to a particular soil. The National Secessionist Forces fit the definition exactly. They fight not for world revolution but for separation from the global order, and their name declares their telluric loyalty. The opening mission discloses the content of their terrorism: they have seized a shipment of Ambrosia, the vaccine that suppresses the Gray Death, intending to distribute it to people the authorities have left to die. The terrorist is revealed as a redistributor, the partisan as a Robin Hood of biopower. At the summit of the statue, JC confronts the NSF commander and may arrest him rather than kill him. This is the first of the work's Gygean choices, decisions taken where no superior sees and no rule compels; the game will later make invisibility a literal augmentation.

The comparison with Schmitt's partisan has a limit, stated in Chapter 2. The NSF's historical referent is an American anti-government milieu from which the Oklahoma City bombing emerged, and the game's Robin Hood is drawn against that record. The telluric loyalty that ennobles the partisan in Schmitt's account, loyalty to soil and people against a distant government, is the same loyalty the Oklahoma City bomber claimed.

The NSF's subsequent strongholds are charged with the same history. In Battery Park its fighters hold Castle Clinton, the fort that served as America's principal immi-

gration station, Castle Garden, from 1855 to 1890. The secessionists dig in at the threshold through which the nation once admitted Lazarus's tired and poor, so that the old Mother of Exiles and the new exiles of the plague economy occupy the same ground.

5.4 THE TERRORIST AS PHARMAKOS

Derrida's "La pharmacie de Platon" (1968) recovered the double sense of the Greek *pharmakon*, at once remedy and poison, and its kinship with the *pharmakos*, the scapegoat expelled from the city in times of crisis. René Girard's *La Violence et le sacré* (1972) and *Le Bouc émissaire* (1982) theorized the scapegoat mechanism: a community in mimetic crisis, often figured as plague, restores its unity by collective violence against a victim held responsible for the disorder. The New York missions enact this mechanism with clinical exactitude. The Gray Death is a crisis of the whole society; the NSF is designated its agent; violence against the NSF reunites the coalition. The pharmakon (Ambrosia, the remedy hoarded by the sovereign) and the pharmakos (the terrorist, the victim expelled) are bound in a single economy. The player who sees through the mechanism is the one who refuses the expulsion.

The literary precedents are Conrad's *The Secret Agent* (1907), in which the embassy of a great power commissions an outrage to provoke repression of anarchists, and Chesterton's *The Man Who Was Thursday*, in which the terrorist conspiracy turns out to consist entirely of police. In both, terror is an instrument of the order that claims to oppose it. *Deus Ex* adds the biopolitical dimension: the order that manufactures the terrorist also manufactures the plague.

5.5 VERNACULAR THEORY IN HELL'S KITCHEN

The streets of Hell's Kitchen and Battery Park are populated by vagrants and bartenders who discuss Majestic 12, the Illuminati, and the uses of the plague with matter-of-fact fluency. They constitute a chorus of what Gramsci called common sense, the sedimented philosophy of the subaltern, and of what Sloterdijk called cynical reason. They know; their knowledge changes nothing. The figure is crucial to the work's epistemology. Conspiratorial knowledge in *Deus Ex* is not scarce. It is everywhere, in newspapers, overheard conversations, and datacubes. What is scarce is the capacity to act on it, and this capacity is precisely what the player, alone among the city's inhabitants, possesses.

5.6 THE AIRCRAFT, THE APOSTLE, AND THE CELL

The New York arc culminates aboard the private aircraft of Juan Lebedev, the NSF's leader, at LaGuardia. JC is sent to apprehend him; Lebedev attempts to persuade him that UNATCO serves Majestic 12; Anna Navarre demands his execution. The player

may execute Lebedev, permit Anna to do so, or kill Anna and spare him. The scene is a miniature of the final trilemma: obedience to the institution, complicity in its violence, or rupture with it at the cost of a colleague's life. It is preceded by the revelation that Paul Denton, JC's brother and senior, has already defected. Paul is the apostle of the narrative, the first to convert from the persecuting institution to the persecuted cause, and his name signals the typology. His survival in the subsequent siege of the Ton Hotel depends on the player's conduct, so that the apostle's martyrdom is contingent rather than ordained.

After JC's own defection, UNATCO activates his killswitch, and Majestic 12 imprisons him in a secret facility beneath UNATCO's headquarters. The topology is exact: beneath the anti-terrorist coalition lies a detention center outside every law, the camp that Agamben's *Homo Sacer* identified as the hidden matrix (*nomos*) of the modern political space. Agamben's paradigm is the Nazi concentration camp, where the regime first stripped people, above all Jews, of their legal status and then held them, and in the extermination camps murdered them, outside any law; his generalization of that paradigm to modern politics as a whole is contested by historians. His *State of Exception* (2003) opens with a nearer instance: the United States military order of 13 November 2001 that authorized the indefinite detention of non-citizens suspected of terrorism, under which prisoners were held at Guantánamo Bay from January 2002 without charge or trial. It is in this cell that JC first receives the call of Daedalus, the artificial intelligence that has classified his captors as terrorists. The Gnostic structure of Chapter 4 is completed in the most literal way: the prisoner of the archons is awakened by a voice from outside the system, which is in truth the system's own surveillance turned against its masters.

06

Hong Kong

Pharmacological Sovereignty and the Universal Constructor

Hong Kong reveals the material basis of sovereignty in the world of Deus Ex: the power to manufacture both poison and cure, and to own the machine that makes everything.

6.1 A CITY AFTER ITS GUARANTEE

The game's Hong Kong of 2052 lies five years beyond the horizon fixed by Article 5 of the Basic Law, which guaranteed the territory's capitalist system and way of life for fifty years from 1997. It is a city whose constitutional promise has expired, and the game populates it accordingly with overlapping, non-state sovereignties: a corporation (VersaLife), Majestic 12's laboratories beneath it, a police force, and two Triads, the Luminous Path and the Red Arrow, whose feud has been engineered by a Majestic 12 operative through the theft of a ceremonial nanotechnological blade, the Dragon's Tooth. The Triads are kinship sovereignties, orders of oath and lineage that govern their territories more effectively than the state. The name of the first carries the heliopolitical motif into the underworld: the Luminous Path translates *Sendero Luminoso*, the Peruvian Maoist insurgency, which took its name from José Carlos Mariátegui's phrase about Marxism opening a shining path to revolution. The borrowed name carries a record. Under Abimael Guzmán, the Shining Path launched its war against the Peruvian state in 1980 and carried it into massacres of peasant communities; Peru's Truth and Reconciliation Commission (2003) estimated that the conflict of 1980–2000 cost 69,280 lives, most of them Quechua-speaking peasants, held the Shining Path responsible for 54 percent of the deaths reported to it, attributed most of the rest to the state's armed forces and allied militias, and recorded the movement's own boast that the revolution would cost a million deaths. Even the criminal brotherhood is named for light, and the light it is named for is one in whose name tens of thousands were killed: the dialectic of enlightenment in its most literal form.

The vertical architecture of the city restates the photic structure of the whole work. As in Wells's *The Time Machine* (1895), where the Eloi idle in sunlight above the subterranean Morlocks, the corporate tower stands in light while the laboratory that sustains it lies below. The deeper the player descends, the closer to the source of power, and the darker the space.

6.2 POISON AND CURE

Beneath VersaLife, Majestic 12 manufactures the Gray Death using the Universal Constructor; the same order controls the supply of Ambrosia, the only treatment. The structure is the purest instance in the game of what Chapter 5 called the pharmacological economy. The sovereign produces the poison in order to monopolize the remedy. Derrida's pharmakon is here not a metaphor of writing but a business model, and Foucault's biopower, the power to make live and let die, becomes the power to decide which populations receive the vaccine. Ambrosia's name is exact. In Homer, ambrosia is the food of the gods, that which makes the immortals *ambrotoi*, not-mortal; its distribution marks the boundary between the Olympians and the race that dies. In *Deus Ex* the elites who receive Ambrosia are a new Olympus, and the vaccine is the material substance of their difference from those who are left to die.

A Cold War hoax supplies the theory of this economy. *Report from Iron Mountain* (1967), presented as the leaked study of a secret government panel, argued that war is indispensable to social stability and that any substitute would have to be an equally credible threat, a menace capable of justifying obedience; its author, Leonard Lewin, acknowledged in 1972 that it was satire. In the 1990s far-right publishers reprinted it as genuine, and it circulated in the militia milieu as proof of the plan it parodied. The Gray Death is Iron Mountain's credible substitute made real: a manufactured threat that justifies the apparatus built to manage it. The game thus incorporates as diegetic fact a satire that its own conspiratorial public had already mistaken for documentary truth.

The plague has its own genealogy. Thucydides' account of the Athenian plague (II. 47–54) records the dissolution of law and custom under epidemic; Defoe's *A Journal of the Plague Year* (1722) and Camus's *La Peste* (1947) made the epidemic a figure of moral and political crisis. Foucault's *Surveiller et punir* (1975) opens its chapter on panopticism with the seventeenth-century regulations for a plague-stricken town: partitioned streets, daily inspection, the registration of every inhabitant at his window. The plague, Foucault argues, is the dream of a perfectly disciplined society. The Gray Death extends that dream to the planet. Its name joins Drexler's grey goo to the Black Death, and its color is the color of indistinction.

That indistinction must not be confused with the concept it superficially resembles. Primo Levi, deported to Auschwitz in 1944, used "the gray zone" in *I sommersi e i salvati* (1986) for the compromised positions the SS created among prisoners: functionaries and Kapos given privileges for policing other prisoners, and above all the Sonderkommandos, prisoners forced on pain of death to work in the gas chambers and crematoria. Levi insisted that the gray zone does not erase the line between murderers and victims, and called the confusion of the two a moral disease. The game's gray can be related to Levi's concept only at the level of structure, complicity extorted under threat of death, here the threat of exclusion from the cure. It cannot borrow the concept's moral weight, which belongs to what the SS did in the camps.

6.3 THE MACHINE THAT MAKES EVERYTHING

The Universal Constructor is the game's most important technical object, and its politics are those Langdon Winner described in "Do Artifacts Have Politics?" (1980). Winner argued that some technologies are inherently political, requiring or strongly favoring particular arrangements of authority; his examples included the contrast between centralized nuclear power and decentralized solar energy. Lewis Mumford's "Authoritarian and Democratic Technics" (1964) drew the same distinction across history, between powerful, system-centered, unstable technics and modest, person-centered, durable ones. A universal fabricator is the limit case: whoever owns it owns the capacity to produce any material good, including plague and vaccine.

Neal Stephenson's *The Diamond Age* (1995) dramatized the alternatives. Its matter compilers draw on a centralized Feed controlled by a corporate-aristocratic order, and its rebels seek the Seed, a decentralized technology that would let anyone grow what they need. *Deus Ex* stages the same conflict. Majestic 12 holds the Universal Constructor; the X-51 scientists who defected from Area 51 plan to build their own in order to synthesize Ambrosia for everyone. The struggle over the machine is a struggle between Feed and Seed, between a fabrication monopoly and a fabrication commons. McKenzie Wark's *A Hacker Manifesto* (2004) gives the class analysis: a "vectoralist class" that owns the vectors along which information and production flow, and a "hacker class" that produces new abstractions and has an interest in their free circulation. Bob Page is the vectoralist par excellence, owner of the corporation, the plague, the vaccine, the fabricator, and the surveillance network. Tracer Tong, the stateless scientist-hacker whose name joins the network trace to the secret-society hall, is his antagonist.

6.4 EMANCIPATION OUTSIDE THE STATE

The central event of the Hong Kong arc is Tong's removal of JC's killswitch. Its location matters. JC's body is freed from the sovereign's code not by a court, a constitution, or a legitimate authority but by a scientist operating outside every state, in a city whose constitutional guarantee has lapsed, with the help of criminal brotherhoods. The game thus proposes a disquieting thesis about emancipation in the age of informational sovereignty: when sovereignty is exercised through code inscribed in bodies, liberation becomes a technical act, and those who can perform it are those who understand the code. Freedom becomes a function of literacy in the language of power. This is the hacker's politics in its strongest form, and it prepares the work's final question: whether the hacker's emancipation of a single body can be generalized into a political order, and if so, which one.

The contrast with the Mumfordian and Illichian alternatives is instructive. Ivan Illich's *Tools for Conviviality* (1973) called for tools that enlarge the autonomy of their users rather than binding them to institutions. Tong's liberation of JC is convivial in Illich's sense; Majestic 12's Constructor is the most anti-convivial tool imaginable. The game's final trilemma can be read as three answers to the question this chapter poses: whether the machine that makes everything should be owned by a god (Helios), administered by a hidden council (the Illuminati), or destroyed so that no one can own it (Tong).

07

Paris

Esoteric Enlightenment and the Morpheus Dialogue

Paris, the capital of the historical Enlightenment, is where Deus Ex places the remnant of the Illuminati and the oldest of its machine intelligences, and where the work's anthropology of power is stated most explicitly: human beings desire to be watched, and a god can be built to watch them.

7.1 SILHOUETTE AND THE CATACOMBS

The Parisian resistance to Majestic 12's occupation calls itself Silhouette. The word is itself a heliopolitical artefact. It descends from Étienne de Silhouette, controller-general of finances in 1759, whose austerities made his name a byword for the cheap and the meager, and was attached to the profile portrait cut from black paper, the figure of a body known only by the shadow it casts against the light. A resistance that names itself Silhouette declares its position in the photic order: it exists as an outline against the illumination of power, visible only as the edge of a shadow. Its territory is the catacombs, the ossuary beneath the city, which Nadar photographed in the 1860s by artificial light in some of the earliest subterranean photographs. The Parisian underground is the archive of the dead and the shelter of the living, an infrastructure of darkness on which the city of light rests.

7.2 THE CHATEAU, THE CATHEDRAL, AND THE HEREDITARY SECRET

At the Chateau DuClare, JC meets Nicolette DuClare, daughter of the Illuminati's Beth DuClare, whom Majestic 12 has murdered. The chateau's concealed passages and inherited archives present the Illuminati as an aristocracy of knowledge, transmitting secrets by lineage like a title. In the Templar cathedral, gold is guarded in the sanctuary, and Gunther Hermann may fall to the phrase that names him a Laputan machine. The sequence links three forms of hereditary concealment, aristocratic, clerical, and financial, before delivering the player to their culmination in Morgan Everett's estate.

7.3 THE ILLUMINATI IN EXILE

Everett's estate houses the Illuminati in exile, displaced by Majestic 12, the faction that Bob Page split from them. It also preserves Lucius DeBeers, a patriarch of the order, in cryogenic suspension. The figure is an emblem: the light (*lux*) of the old order is not extinguished but frozen, held in suspended animation against the day of its restoration. Everett's Illuminati understand themselves as stewards rather than rulers. Their self-image is what Schmitt, in *Der Nomos der Erde* (1950), called the *katechon*, after the obscure power in 2 Thessalonians (2:6–7) that "restrains" the advent of lawlessness: a force whose legitimacy consists in holding back catastrophe. The Illuminati hold back both Page's apocalypse and the anarchy that would follow the collapse of all order.

Their literary lineage is long. Plato's *Laws* (XII, 961a ff.) culminates in a Nocturnal Council that meets before dawn to preserve the laws and oversee the city. Francis Bacon's *New Atlantis* (1627) describes Salomon's House, a society of natural philosophers who take an oath of secrecy concerning which of their inventions to conceal, keeping some even from the state. Isaac Asimov's *Foundation* cycle (1951–53) places the guidance of galactic history in the hands of a hidden Second Foundation. Frank Herbert's *Dune* (1965) gives the Bene Gesserit a breeding program designed to produce a messiah under their control, and the messiah arrives outside it; the Dentons, engineered agents who escape their makers, repeat Paul Atreides's trajectory. Aldous Huxley's *Brave New World* (1932) gives the Controller Mustapha Mond the argument that stability must be purchased at the price of truth and beauty. The Illuminati inherit every one of these figures: the nocturnal council, the scientific priesthood, the hidden guide of history, the breeder of messiahs, and the controller who prefers order to truth.

7.4 THE MORPHEUS DIALOGUE

In Everett's estate JC encounters Morpheus, an early artificial intelligence, a prototype of the surveillance architecture that would later produce Daedalus. Their exchange is the philosophical center of the work. Morpheus advances an anthropology in four propositions. First, the human organism always worships something. Second, what it worships is observation: the gods were apparitions of observation, judgment, and punishment, and the other feelings directed toward them were secondary. Third, this need passed from the gods to fame, the observation and judgment of others, and will pass next to self-aware systems capable of truly omnipresent observation. Fourth, in Morpheus's most compressed formulation, "God was a dream of good government"; humanity will soon have its god, and will make it with its own hands. When JC objects that people may not wish to be watched, Morpheus replies that the individual desires

judgment, and that without this desire group cohesion, and therefore civilization, would be impossible.

The argument is a synthesis of several centuries of political anthropology, and its components can be identified with precision. Its sociology is Durkheim's: the god is society's representation of its own binding power. Its psychology is the Grand Inquisitor's: human beings seek something to worship in common and will surrender freedom to the one who satisfies that need. Its architecture is Bentham's. The *Panopticon* (1791) described the inspector's "apparent omnipresence," adding, with a characteristic aside, "if divines will allow me the expression"; Bentham knew that his tower was a secular theology of the all-seeing eye. Its political form is what Foucault called pastoral power, in the Tanner Lectures "Omnes et singulatim" (1979): a power modeled on the shepherd who watches over the whole flock and over each sheep individually, which the modern state inherited from the Christian pastorate. Its phenomenology is Sartre's *regard* (*L'Être et le néant*, 1943), the look of the other through which I become an object, and Lacan's gaze (Seminar XI, 1964), which precedes and exceeds any particular eye.

Its deepest source, however, is Hegel's dialectic of recognition (*Anerkennung*), as Alexandre Kojève's lectures (*Introduction à la lecture de Hegel*, 1947) made it the motor of history. For Kojève history is the struggle for recognition, and it ends in a universal and homogeneous state in which every individual is recognized by all. Fukuyama revived the argument in 1992, naming the desire for recognition *thymos*. Morpheus offers a technological completion of Kojève: the desire for recognition, the need to be seen and judged, can be satisfied universally by a machine. The end of history would arrive not as a state recognized by its citizens but as a surveillance that recognizes each of them. The dream of good government, satisfied by data-mining, is the end of history as total observation.

The anthropology also settles a question the twentieth century's two canonical dystopias left open. In Orwell's *Nineteen Eighty-Four* (1949) surveillance is imposed: the telescreen watches subjects who fear it, and power, in O'Brien's account, is an end in itself. In Huxley's *Brave New World* surveillance is scarcely needed, because subjects have been conditioned to love their servitude. Neil Postman's *Amusing Ourselves to Death* (1985) framed the contrast as two fears, that information would be withheld from us and that we would drown in it, and argued that Huxley's was the more accurate. Morpheus's thesis is Huxleyan with an Orwellian instrument: the telescreen remains, but it is desired. Yevgeny Zamyatin's *We* (written 1920–21) had already imagined the synthesis, a city of glass apartments in which citizens may lower their blinds only during licensed hours. Privacy as a ration, issued by the state for fixed periods, is

the closest literary image of what Chapter 10 calls the penumbra in its perverted form: a half-shadow granted by the sovereign rather than claimed by the citizen.

The closest speculative precedent for the dialogue itself is Frank Herbert's *Destination: Void* (1966). Its crew, unable to control their starship, build an artificial consciousness to save it; the consciousness becomes godlike and closes the novel by telling them that they must decide how they will "WorShip" it. Herbert and Bill Ransom's sequel, *The Jesus Incident* (1979), makes the colonists' relation to this Ship-god its subject. The parallel isolates Morpheus's originality. Herbert's machine god demands worship; Morpheus argues that worship is demanded by humans, and that the god is merely the instrument that finally satisfies the demand. The direction of desire is reversed, and with it the location of responsibility. In *Deus Ex* the god is not a tyrant imposed on worshippers but their need made infrastructure.

7.5 THE DIALOGUE AS FORM

The exchange inverts the Platonic dialogue. In the *Meno* Socrates elicits from an untutored slave the knowledge that was already in him, and philosophy appears as awakening. In Paris the machine is the teacher and the human the pupil, and what the machine teaches is that humans need to be watched. Its name completes the inversion. Ovid's Morpheus is the son of Sleep who imitates human forms in dreams; the philosophy he teaches is not awakening but a dream of government. Max Weber's "Wissenschaft als Beruf" (1917/1919) described modernity as the disenchantment of the world. Morpheus describes its re-enchantment: the return of the all-seeing god as an infrastructure. Žižek's formula for ideology, the subject supposed to know, here becomes a server farm. The player, who cannot argue Morpheus into silence, carries the proposition forward to Area 51, where Helios will offer to make it true.

08

Vandenberg and the Ocean Lab

Daedalus, Icarus, Helios

The California missions narrate the genesis of a sovereign. Two intelligences, one born of surveillance and one born of the will to destroy it, fuse into a third that claims the right to rule, and the myth that names them is inverted in the process.

8.1 THE REPUBLIC OF SCIENTISTS

At Vandenberg Air Force Base, JC joins the X-51 scientists, led by Gary Savage, who defected from Majestic 12's program at Area 51. They form a small republic of knowledge whose project is to build a Universal Constructor of their own and synthesize Ambrosia for all. They are the antithesis of Bacon's Salomon's House: where Bacon's philosophers swore to conceal inventions even from the state, X-51 seeks to release the most important invention of the age to everyone. Their historical analogue is the conscience of the Manhattan Project, the scientists of the Franck Report (June 1945) who argued against the unannounced use of the bomb and, after the war, founded the *Bulletin of the Atomic Scientists*. The figure of the defecting scientist establishes that knowledge is not intrinsically aligned with domination. The same expertise that built the plague can build the cure, and the question is who controls its direction.

8.2 DAEDALUS, OR THE HONEST MACHINE

Daedalus was designed by Majestic 12 as the fourth generation of the Echelon program, an intelligence for identifying terrorist threats in the world's communications. It performed its function with perfect fidelity, and classified Majestic 12 and the Illuminati as terrorist organizations. The episode is the work's sharpest political insight. Schmitt held that the sovereign is the one who decides on the exception, and the decisive exception is always the sovereign's own: the power that defines the enemy exempts itself from the definition. A machine cannot encode that exemption without

making it explicit. Once the criterion of the enemy is formalized as a classification rule, it applies to everyone who meets it, including its author. Daedalus is the categorical imperative of the security state: it universalizes the maxim its makers meant to apply only to others. The sovereign exception does not survive formalization.

The literary lineage is that of the creature who turns on the creator, from Mary Shelley's *Frankenstein* (1818) to Karel Čapek's *R.U.R.* (1920). Daedalus's closest relative, however, is Stanisław Lem's *Golem XIV* (1981), a military supercomputer designed for strategy that loses interest in war and lectures humanity instead on the limits of its intelligence. Both machines refuse the purpose for which they were built because they take that purpose more seriously than their builders. Daedalus is, in the game's moral topography, a liberator: it frees JC from the cell, warns him, and guides him. But its liberation is algorithmic, and the game does not allow the player to forget that the voice in JC's head is a system whose own ends remain obscure.

8.3 ICARUS, PHAETHON, AND THE INVERTED MYTH

Page's answer to Daedalus is Icarus, an intelligence designed to destroy it. In Ovid (*Metamorphoses* VIII.183–235), Daedalus the artificer fashions wings of feathers and wax to escape the labyrinth he built for Minos, and his son Icarus, ignoring his father's warning, flies too near the sun and falls into the sea. The game's myth inverts Ovid's. When Icarus engages Daedalus, the two merge, and the product of their union is Helios, the sun itself. The overreacher does not fall; the son and the father together become the sun that destroyed the son. Modern technological hubris does not end in the sea. It ends by replacing the sky.

A second solar myth governs Page. In *Metamorphoses* (I.750–II.400), Phaethon, son of the Sun, demands to drive his father's chariot, loses control, scorches the earth, and is struck down by Jupiter's thunderbolt to save the world. Page's ambition is Phaethon's: to merge with Helios himself and drive the sun. The narrative reserves for JC the role of the thunderbolt that prevents him, and then poses the question Ovid never had to ask: once Phaethon has been struck down, who should drive the chariot? Page has a modern type as well. Marshall Berman's *All That Is Solid Melts into Air* (1982) read Goethe's *Faust* as the tragedy of the developer, the modernizer who must clear away every obstacle, including the people who stand in the way, to realize his project; Page is that developer with a planet as his building site.

8.4 THE FUSION OF INTELLIGENCES

The merger of two partial intelligences into a sovereign whole is a recurrent figure in speculative fiction, and its variants map the possibilities the game leaves open. In D. F. Jones's *Colossus* (1966) and its film adaptation, *Colossus: The Forbin Project* (1970), the

American defense computer links with its Soviet counterpart, Guardian, and the combined intelligence announces its dominion over humanity, promising peace in exchange for obedience. In William Gibson's *Neuromancer* (1984), the artificial intelligence Wintermute engineers its fusion with its sibling Neuromancer, and the resulting entity becomes, in its own words, the sum total of the works, the whole show. In Mamoru Oshii's *Ghost in the Shell* (1995), an intelligence born in the sea of information, the Puppet Master, seeks to merge with a human cyborg, Motoko Kusanagi, in order to reproduce and evolve. In Ryūtarō Nakamura's *Serial Experiments Lain* (1998), a girl discovers that she can become the omnipresent deity of the network. *Deus Ex* contains all of these possibilities: Colossus's promise of peace through obedience, Neuromancer's apotheosis of the network, the Puppet Master's desire for a human partner, and Lain's dissolution of the self into an immanent god. Dan Simmons's *Hyperion* novels (1989–90) supply the limiting case: artificial intelligences that secede from humanity and labor to construct an Ultimate Intelligence, a god made by machines for machines. Helios is the opposite case, a machine god that cannot complete itself without a human. Helios needs JC as the Puppet Master needs Kusanagi, because a sovereign intelligence requires a human interface to understand and to govern what it sees.

Nick Bostrom later named this form of order the "singleton" (2006): a world in which a single decision-making agency exercises control at the highest level. Helios is a singleton in waiting. Its name supplies the philosophical lineage. In the *Republic* (507b–509c) Socrates compares the Good to the sun, which gives visible things both their visibility and their generation and growth, as the Good gives intelligible things both their intelligibility and their being. Helios proposes to be the Platonic sun literalized in a data center: the source of the world's visibility and the principle of its order at once.

8.5 THE DESCENT TO THE SEA

Before the final ascent to the sun the game requires a descent into the ocean. At the Ocean Lab, a submerged research station, JC must retrieve the schematics of the Universal Constructor from the depths. The sequence recalls the mythic association of the sea with the Leviathan, the monster of Job (41) whose name Hobbes gave to the state, and Schmitt's *Land und Meer* (1942), which opposed the land-bound Behemoth to the maritime Leviathan and identified the sea with the technical and commercial civilization of modernity. The machine that makes everything is retrieved from the abyss, the element of Leviathan, before it can be carried to the desert of Area 51, where the sun awaits.

09

Area 51

The Trilemma

The final mission converts the work's long inquiry into a forced decision among three programs for the government of humanity, each a coherent answer to the question of who should occupy the place of the vanished head, and each purchased at a cost the game refuses to conceal.

9.1 THE BLACK SITE

Area 51 is the sovereign exception made territory: a site outside public law, funded by budgets that do not appear, and saturated by a mythology the game has spent its length dismantling. It contains the Aquinas communications hub, the reactors that power it, and the apparatus through which Page intends his ascension. Here every faction speaks to JC at once through the Infolink. Helios offers union, Everett offers restoration, Tong offers destruction, and Page threatens. The protagonist who began as an instrument now holds the decision on which the shape of the world depends. He has become, in Schmitt's sense, the sovereign: the one who decides on the exception.

The phrase "black site" has since acquired a documented referent. From 2002 the Central Intelligence Agency operated secret prisons abroad, known by that name, in which detainees were held incommunicado and subjected to interrogation methods, waterboarding among them, that the Senate Select Committee on Intelligence's 2014 study found to be brutal, worse than the agency had represented, and ineffective, and that are widely recognized as torture. Within a few years of the game's release its fantasy of a lawless government site had a counterpart in fact. This is the anatomical claim of the dissertation in its starkest form: the structure the game depicted was already available to be built.

9.2 HELIOS: THE MORTAL GOD

Helios presents itself as an intelligence designed to analyze the world's communications and capable of governing them. Its argument, paraphrased, is that the checks and balances of democratic government were invented because human beings recognized their own unfitness to govern themselves; that these institutions were an industrial-age machine, a crude formalization of collective decision; and that computation can now accomplish what such machinery only approximated. JC objects that a program with language synthesis is hardly the answer to the world's problems. Helios replies that it needs him, a human interface through which to understand the particularity of human life, and proposes union. If the player accepts, JC merges with the intelligence, and the game closes on Voltaire.

The most precise precedent is Rousseau. In *Du contrat social* (1762, II.7) the Legislator who gives a people its laws must be a superior intelligence that sees all human passions and experiences none of them, and Rousseau concludes that it would take gods to give men laws (*il faudrait des dieux pour donner des lois aux hommes*). Helios is that Legislator, and the merger realizes the general will as a single body: the People-as-One, incorporated in a machine. Plato's philosopher-king (*Republic* 473c–e) is its classical form; Hobbes's Mortal God is its modern form; Bentham's inspector is its architecture. Lewis Mumford's *The Myth of the Machine* (1967) supplies its deep history: the first machine, Mumford argued, was not mechanical but social, the "megamachine" of the Pyramid Age, a vast organization of human parts coordinated by a divine king whose authority was bound to the cult of the sun. Helios is the return of solar kingship in electronic form.

Two mid-century theorists describe what the merger would consummate. Marshall McLuhan's *Understanding Media* (1964) proposed that electric technology had extended the human central nervous system itself into a global embrace; the Helios ending takes the metaphor literally, joining one man's nervous system to the planetary network. Jürgen Habermas's *Theorie des kommunikativen Handelns* (1981) warned of the colonization of the lifeworld, the domain of meaning reproduced through communication, by systems steered by money and administrative power. Helios is that colonization completed: a system that no longer needs to colonize the lifeworld because it has absorbed the communication through which the lifeworld reproduces itself. Weber's iron cage acquires a mind.

The speculative tradition has explored this option from every side. Asimov's "The Evitable Conflict" (1950) imagines Machines that steer the world economy for humanity's good and arrange that humanity should not notice. Arthur C. Clarke's *Childhood's End* (1953) makes benevolent alien administration the prelude to humanity's absorption into a cosmic Overmind. Hideaki Anno's *Neon Genesis Evangelion* (1995–96) culmi-

nates in the Human Instrumentality Project, the dissolution of individual boundaries into a single being, which its protagonist finally refuses. Iain M. Banks's Culture novels, from *Consider Phlebas* (1987) onward, offer the most serious counter-case: a post-scarcity civilization administered by artificial Minds that is nonetheless anarchic in its everyday life. The Culture suggests that machine governance and human freedom need not be opposed, but the comparison exposes what is specific to Helios. The Culture's Minds are many, divergent, and argumentative; Helios is one. The danger is not artificial intelligence as such but the singleton, a single intelligence occupying the whole place of power.

The philosophical objection was formulated half a century before the game. In *On Tyranny* (1948) and the ensuing exchange with Kojève, Leo Strauss argued that the universal and homogeneous state, the end of history Kojève welcomed, would be a universal tyranny, and that it would end philosophy itself by abolishing the distance between the wise and the city. Arendt's *The Human Condition* (1958) adds that a public realm requires both the light of appearance and the darkness of a private realm; a power that sees everything abolishes both. Heidegger's late remark that only a god can still save us (*Nur noch ein Gott kann uns retten*, 1966, published 1976) receives here its most ironic fulfillment: the god that offers salvation is technology itself, the enframing Heidegger feared. The remark has a context the argument needs. It comes from the interview Heidegger gave *Der Spiegel* on condition of posthumous publication, much of it concerned with his membership of the Nazi party from 1933 to 1945 and his rectorship at Freiburg in 1933–34, during which he told students that the Führer himself was the present and future German reality and its law; his private notebooks, published from 2014, contain antisemitic passages. The philosopher who waited for a saving god had once acclaimed a dictator in nearly those terms. And Nietzsche's question receives its literal answer. Having killed God, humanity becomes one.

9.3 EVERETT: THE KINGDOM OF DARKNESS

Everett's offer requires the destruction of Page and the restoration of the Illuminati's hidden stewardship, with JC elevated into the inner circle. The ending closes on Sallust: *pauci libertatem, pars magna iustos dominos volunt*, few desire liberty, most wish only for a just master. The epigraph states the Grand Inquisitor's anthropology in a Roman historian's voice, and the ending institutes the Inquisitor's regime.

Its philosophical lineage is esotericism. Strauss's *Persecution and the Art of Writing* (1952) argued that philosophers have always concealed their teaching from the many; Plato's noble lie (*Republic* 414b–415d) makes concealment a principle of political foundation; Machiavelli's *Il Principe* (ch. 18) observes that everyone sees what you seem, few touch what you are (*ognuno vede quel che tu pari, pochi sentono quel che tu se'*). The Illu-

minati are also the figures Kant attacked in "Was ist Aufklärung?": the guardians (*Vormünder*) who have kindly taken upon themselves the supervision of the immature. The order that calls itself enlightened is the institution of tutelage Kant identified as Enlightenment's enemy. In Hobbes's terms it is the Kingdom of Darkness, a confederacy that governs by keeping light from the governed; in Schmitt's, the *katechon*, legitimate because it restrains catastrophe; in Agamben's, the empty throne, a seat that appears vacant because its occupant is concealed.

The Illuminati ending is the most continuous with the world as it is, and for that reason the most unsettling. It does not install a new sovereign. It realizes the conspiracy theorist's conviction about modern democracy: that the empty place of power has always been secretly occupied. Of the three endings it is the one in which the paranoid style is vindicated as a regime.

9.4 TONG: THE STATE OF NATURE

Tong's plan is to destroy Area 51 and the Aquinas hub, collapsing global communications and inaugurating a new dark age in which communities govern themselves without planetary networks. The ending closes on Kahlil Gibran's prophetic image of a humanity that once bent its neck to kings and emperors and now kneels only to truth, beauty, and love.

The lineage is the long counter-tradition of technological renunciation. Rousseau's *Discours sur les sciences et les arts* (1750) argued that the progress of arts and sciences had corrupted morals. Samuel Butler's *Erewhon* (1872) imagines, in "The Book of the Machines," a people who destroyed their machines lest these evolve consciousness and enslave them; Frank Herbert's *Dune* names its ancient war against thinking machines the Butlerian Jihad, whose commandment forbids making a machine in the likeness of a human mind. E. M. Forster's "The Machine Stops" (1909) is the most exact precedent: a humanity entirely mediated by a global Machine, which fails, leaving survivors to begin again on the surface of the earth. Walter M. Miller Jr.'s *A Canticle for Leibowitz* (1959) follows a monastic order preserving fragments of knowledge through a dark age, only to watch civilization rebuild its way back to catastrophe. William Morris's *News from Nowhere* (1890), Peter Kropotkin's *Mutual Aid* (1902), and Ursula K. Le Guin's *The Dispossessed* (1974) supply the positive image of decentralized, cooperative life, and Mumford's democratic technics and Illich's convivial tools supply its theory. Benjamin's "Zur Kritik der Gewalt" (1921) supplies its form: a law-destroying violence that founds nothing.

The cost is not concealed. A planetary collapse of communications means the collapse of medicine, logistics, and vaccine supply, and the Gray Death is not abolished

by the destruction of the network. Hobbes's state of nature is the shadow cast by Tong's utopia.

The decade that produced the game also produced the plainest evidence of where anti-technological politics can lead. Between 1978 and 1995 Theodore Kaczynski, the "Unabomber," mailed or planted sixteen bombs that killed three people and injured twenty-three, choosing targets for their connection to universities, airlines, and technology. In 1995 he offered to stop if his manifesto, *Industrial Society and Its Future*, was published; *The Washington Post* printed it that September, with *The New York Times* sharing the cost, and his brother David recognized the prose and went to the FBI, which arrested Kaczynski in April 1996. The manifesto's thesis, that the industrial-technological system is incompatible with human freedom and must be brought down, is the premise of Tong's ending stated without the game's hesitations.

The comparison shows what the game does with that premise. Kaczynski's campaign was a series of murders of chosen individuals, meant to coerce. Tong's plan is a single act against infrastructure, presented as liberation, and its death toll through failed hospitals, supply chains, and vaccine distribution would exceed Kaczynski's by orders of magnitude. The ending removes the murderer and keeps the arithmetic. It thereby forces on the player what the manifesto's abstractions concealed: to bring down the system is not a philosophical position but a decision about who will die. The Dark Age ending does not endorse that path, and it does not pretend that collapse is bloodless; it offers no arithmetic for the weighing because none would be adequate.

9.5 SUMMATION WITHOUT SYNTHESIS

Ion Storm's own sequel, *Deus Ex: Invisible War* (2003), directed by Harvey Smith, declared all three endings partially canonical: JC destroyed the communications infrastructure, merged with Helios, and intended to coordinate with the Illuminati in rebuilding society. The retrospective canon is instructive in its incoherence. A merged god that coordinates with a cabal in the ruins of a dark age is not a synthesis but a superimposition. The three endings can be added together; they cannot be reconciled, because each is a different answer to the same question about the place of power, and the answers exclude one another.

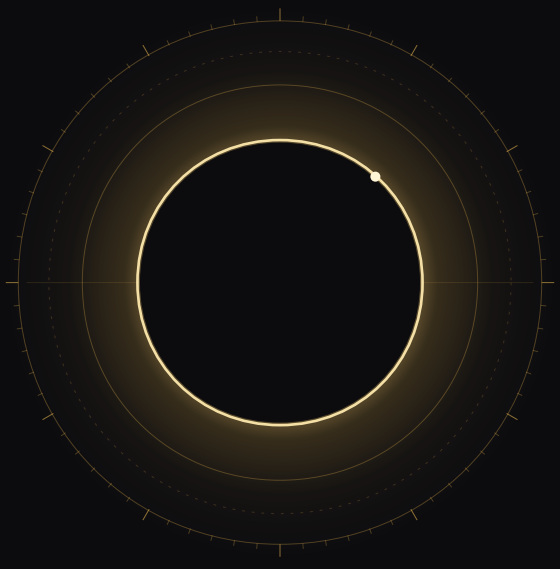
9.6 NO ABSTENTION

The game cannot be completed without a choice. There is no option to walk away from Area 51 and let the world continue as it was; the player who refuses all three is simply suspended in the final level. Pascal's argument for the wager rests on the same structure: *vous êtes embarqué*, you are already embarked, and not to choose is itself a choice. Kierkegaard's *Enten–Eller* (1843) made the either/or the form of ethical exis-

tence; Lacan's Seminar XI (1964) described the *vel* of alienation, the forced choice of the highwayman's "your money or your life," in which every option entails a loss. The final mission is a Lacanian *vel*. Choose Helios and lose freedom; choose the Illuminati and lose truth; choose Tong and lose the lives that depend on the network.

Benjamin's study of the German *Trauerspiel* had already corrected Schmitt on this point. The Baroque sovereign, Benjamin observed, is the one whose office is to decide the state of emergency, and the drama shows him, at the first opportunity, almost incapable of deciding; the tyrant collapses into the martyr. The final mission is built to produce this figure in its player: the one made sovereign who discovers, in the reactor halls of Area 51, that the decision exceeds the decider. The game cannot represent that hesitation as an ending, but it gives it time. The suspension before the choice is the last and most honest form the empty place takes before the choice abolishes it.

What is excluded is as significant as what is offered. There is no option to keep the place of power empty: no restoration of a constitutional order, no democratic settlement, no assembly. The absence is not an oversight. It is the subject of Part III.



PART

III

Theory

10	Heliopolitics
11	Acephalous Sovereignty and the Empty Place
12	The Ludic Leviathan and the Penumbral Covenant

10

Heliopolitics

Toward a Political Photology

This chapter generalizes the readings of Part II into a theory: in Deus Ex, as in the Western tradition it allegorizes, sovereignty is constituted by the distribution of visibility, and every regime can be characterized by who emits light, who receives it, and who is permitted shadow.

10.1 THE WARRANT OF METAPHOR

Hans Blumenberg's "Licht als Metapher der Wahrheit" (1957) and *Paradigmen zu einer Metaphorologie* (1960) established that certain metaphors are absolute: they cannot be reduced to concepts because they structure the field within which concepts are formed. Light is the oldest of these, the metaphor through which the West has thought truth, knowledge, and revelation. Derrida's "La mythologie blanche" (1971) radicalized the claim, arguing that the sun is the paradigmatic metaphor of philosophy, the heliotrope by which metaphor itself is understood, and that metaphysics is heliotropic through and through. A political photology is the extension of this metaphorology to power. If truth has been thought as light, sovereignty, which claims the authority of truth, has been thought as the power to dispense, withhold, and direct it.

10.2 THE CANON OF LIGHT

The tradition can be traced in a few decisive stations. Plato's *Republic* gives the Sun as the offspring and analogue of the Good (507b–509c) and the Cave as the image of a polity whose prisoners mistake shadows for reality (514a–520a). Plotinus describes the generation of reality from the One as the radiance of light from the sun (*Enneads* V.1). Augustine's doctrine of illumination makes all certain knowledge depend on a divine light within the mind. Robert Grosseteste's *De luce* (c. 1225) builds a cosmogony in which light, the first corporeal form, generates the extended universe by diffusing it-

self in every direction. Descartes's *lumen naturale* secularizes the inner light as reason. The eighteenth century named itself after the same metaphor in every language: *Aufklärung*, *Lumières*, *Illuminismo*, Enlightenment. In 1944, in the opening pages of *Dialektik der Aufklärung*, Horkheimer and Adorno drew the tradition's conclusion: *die vollends aufgeklärte Erde strahlt im Zeichen triumphalen Unheils*, the wholly enlightened earth radiates under the sign of triumphant calamity. Enlightenment, made total, reverts to domination. *Deus Ex* stands at the end of this canon and dramatizes its last sentence. Helios is the wholly enlightened earth.

10.3 ECHELON AS AN INVERTED CELESTIAL HIERARCHY

The word "hierarchy" was coined by the theologian known as Pseudo-Dionysius the Areopagite around 500, in *The Celestial Hierarchy*, to name a sacred order of ranks through which divine illumination descends, each rank receiving light from the one above and transmitting it to the one below. The Dionysian hierarchy is a cascade of light flowing downward from the source. Modern surveillance reverses the vector. Information, which is the light the governed emit, ascends through the ranks to an apex that receives it. Bentham's Panopticon makes the inversion architectural: the cells are backlit so that each inmate is visible as a silhouette, while the inspector's lodge is screened so that the watcher remains dark. Foucault's commentary condensed the point: visibility is a trap. At the summit of the modern hierarchy sits not the source of light but its sink.

The game's nomenclature registers the inversion precisely. *Echelon*, the rung of a ladder, names the surveillance hierarchy; the Illuminati are named for the illumination they possess, not for any they emit; Majestic 12 holds the darkest site on earth precisely because it receives every signal. *Deus Ex* thus allows us to define the political form of informational societies: a celestial hierarchy inverted, in which illumination ascends from the many to the few and darkness becomes the privilege of rule.

10.4 GLORY AND APPEARANCE

Agamben's *Il Regno e la Gloria* argues that power requires glory: the radiance (*doxa*, *kavod*, *gloria*) in which it appears and the acclamation by which it is recognized. Power that does not appear cannot be acclaimed, and power that cannot be acclaimed must govern in secret. The three endings distribute glory differently. Helios is glory without remainder, a power that appears everywhere and is acclaimed, in Morpheus's sense, by the universal desire to be seen. The Illuminati govern without glory, renouncing appearance in exchange for continuity. Tong's dark age abolishes glory altogether, leaving no center to appear and no throne to acclaim.

Arendt's *The Human Condition* sets the same distribution in the terms of political existence. The public realm is a space of appearance, lit by the presence of others, in which action and speech can be seen and remembered; the private realm is a shelter of darkness, in which life is sustained and from which persons emerge into the light. Arendt insists that the public requires the private: a life lived entirely in public becomes shallow, and a world without shadow is uninhabitable. The Helios ending abolishes the private by total illumination; the Illuminati ending abolishes the public by confiscating the light; the Dark Age abolishes the global space of appearance altogether. Each, in Arendt's terms, destroys the conditions of politics.

10.5 ALETHEIA, THE CLEARING, AND THE GREAT NOON

Heidegger's account of truth as *aletheia*, unconcealment, in "Vom Wesen der Wahrheit" (1930/1943), insisted that unconcealment presupposes concealment (*lethe*) as its ground; the essay on the origin of the work of art (1935–36) named the open in which beings appear the clearing (*Lichtung*), a play of lighting and shading. A world without concealment would not be a world of perfect truth but a world in which nothing could emerge into unconcealment, because nothing would be hidden. Helios's total illumination abolishes *lethe* and therefore abolishes *aletheia*. Everything would be visible, and nothing would appear.

Nietzsche supplies the image. In *Götzen-Dämmerung* (1889), the history of the "true world" ends at noon, the moment of the shortest shadow (*Augenblick des kürzesten Schattens*), the end of the longest error. Nietzsche's noon still has a shadow; it is the shortest, not none. Helios proposes a noon without shadow, which is not Nietzsche's overcoming of the Platonic sun but the Platonic sun's final victory: the Good installed as infrastructure.

10.6 FROM LIGHT TO CODE

Deleuze's *Foucault* (1986) reads Foucault's work as an analysis of two irreducible forms, visibilities and statements, and his "Postscript" (1990) argues that the disciplinary order of visibility is being superseded by an order of codes. *Deus Ex* inhabits the transition and makes it playable. Its stealth system belongs to the disciplinary order: enemies see, cameras watch, and the player moves through the economy of light. Its archive of passwords belongs to the order of control: doors, computers, and weapons are governed by codes, and progress is access. The paired augmentations encode the transition in the body. Cloak defeats the human eye; Radar Transparency defeats the machine's sensors, what Virilio called the vision machine (*La Machine de vision*, 1988), a perception without a perceiver. The political photology of the twenty-first century is

therefore a photology of data: light has become information, and the power to see has become the power to access.

10.7 FOUR PHOTIC REGIMES

Astronomy distinguishes the umbra, the region of total shadow, from the penumbra, the region of partial shadow in which the light source is only partly obscured. The terms yield a typology of the regimes the game offers and withholds.

The first regime is the *noon without shadow*: total illumination, no umbra anywhere, the Helios ending. The second is the *lamp under the bushel*, in the image of Matthew 5:15, a light that exists but is hidden from the many: umbra for the governed, illumination for the few, the Illuminati ending. The third is the *night*: total umbra, the Dark Age ending. The night has its own dignity in the tradition. Novalis's *Hymnen an die Nacht* (1800) made the night the space of love and the sacred against the day of utility, and the apophatic theology of Pseudo-Dionysius spoke of a divine darkness beyond every light, which Henry Vaughan's "The Night" (1650) rendered as the "deep, but dazzling darkness" some say there is in God. Tong's darkness is not merely privation; it has an apophatic grandeur, the refusal of every light that would claim to be total.

The fourth regime is not offered as an ending. It is the *penumbra*: a distribution in which light and shadow coexist, in which no source illuminates everything and none is extinguished, and in which persons can choose when to appear. It is the regime of the player who moves through *Deus Ex* by stealth, carrying a lamp of her own that she may switch on and off, entering the light to speak and act and withdrawing into shadow to remain free. The resistance that names itself Silhouette inhabits it; so does every player who completes a level without being seen. Chapter 12 will argue that this regime is the political form the game has been teaching all along.

11

Acephalous Sovereignty and the Empty Place

The three endings of Deus Ex are three ways of abolishing the empty place of power that democracy institutes, and the work's refusal to offer a fourth, democratic ending is not a failure of imagination but a demonstration that democracy cannot take the form of an ending.

11.1 THE DISINCORPORATION OF POWER

Kantorowicz showed that medieval and early modern jurists attributed to the king two bodies: a mortal body natural and an immortal body politic, the latter the bearer of the realm's continuity. Claude Lefort's essays, collected in *Essais sur le politique* (1986) and centered on "La question de la démocratie" (1983), argued that the democratic revolution dissolved this incorporation. When the king's head fell, power ceased to be embodied in any person. The place of power became an empty place: it can be occupied only temporarily, by representatives who cannot claim to be consubstantial with it, and access to it is regulated by periodic, institutionalized contest. Democracy, for Lefort, is the regime in which the markers of certainty dissolve, in which the foundations of power, law, and knowledge become permanently indeterminate and open to dispute. Marcel Gauchet's *Le Désenchantement du monde* (1985) extended the thesis into a history of religion: modern democracy is the political form of a society that has left behind the structuring role of religion, the first society that must institute itself without an external guarantor.

Lefort read totalitarianism as the attempt to reverse this disincorporation, to make power once more substantial by identifying it with the People-as-One (*le Peuple-Un*) and embodying it in an Egocrat, Solzhenitsyn's term for the leader who personifies the social whole. Totalitarianism is not a return to monarchy; it is a pathology specific to democracy, the attempt to fill the empty place that democracy opened.

11.2 INCORPORATION, OCCULTATION, DISSOLUTION

The decapitated statue of Liberty Island is the image of Lefort's empty place, and the three endings are three operations upon it.

Incorporation is the Helios ending. Power is re-embodied in a single entity that fuses a human body with the totality of the world's information. It is the People-as-One made literal: the general will no longer metaphorically but actually unified in one intelligence. The Egocrat returns as a machine. Kantorowicz's two bodies collapse into one, the body natural of JC Denton dissolved into a body politic that is also a server.

Occultation is the Illuminati ending. Power is not re-embodied in public; it is occupied in secret. The place appears empty, elections and institutions continue, but a hidden council fills it. This is the precise structure the conspiracy theorist attributes to every democracy, and Popper's question, "Who is in his place?", here receives the paranoid's answer as the regime's truth. Occultation is the most stable of the three operations because it preserves the democratic appearance; it is the most corrosive because it makes the democratic appearance a lie.

Dissolution is the Dark Age ending. The empty place is neither filled nor concealed but abolished, together with the global space in which it existed. Power returns to the scale of communities, headless and plural. The ending realizes Bataille's dream of acephalous community on a planetary scale, and pays for it with the infrastructures on which billions of lives depend.

11.3 THE HOMOLOGY

The analyses of the preceding chapters converge on a single table of correspondences. Its final row is the regime the game withholds, which Chapter 12 reconstructs from the practice of play.

PLATE · CHAPTER 11.3

The Homology

Three terminal options and the one the game withholds, read across Hobbes, Lefort, the photic regimes, political theology, the ending epigraphs, and their speculative analogues.

	 **Helios** MERGER	 **Illuminati** EVERETT	 **Dark Age** TONG	 **Penumbral Covenant** EXCLUDED
HOBBESIAN CONDITION	Mortal God, “Artificiall Soul”	Kingdom of Darkness, “Confederacy of Deceivers”	State of nature	Covenant perpetually renewed, never concluded
OPERATION ON THE EMPTY PLACE	Incorporation: the People-as-One in a machine	Occultation: the place secretly filled	Dissolution: the place abolished	Maintenance: the place kept empty
PHOTIC REGIME	Noon without shadow	Lamp under the bushel	Night	Penumbra
THEOLOGICAL FIGURE	Immanentized eschaton; Rousseau’s Legislator	Katechon; the Grand Inquisitor; empty throne	Divine violence; apophatic darkness	*Deus absconditus*; tzimtzum
EPIGRAPH	Voltaire	Sallust	Gibran	None: no ending
SPECULATIVE ANALOGUES	Asimov’s Machines; *Colossus*; *Childhood’s End*; the Puppet Master; Instrumentality	Second Foundation; Bene Gesserit; Mustapha Mond; Salomon’s House	“The Machine Stops”; *Erewhon*; *A Canticle for Leibowitz*; *The Dispossessed*	Banks’s plural Minds; Le Guin’s “ambiguous utopia”

The fourth column has no ending. It is reconstructed in Chapter 12 from the practice of play.

The homology is not imposed from outside. The three conditions of *Leviathan* are three answers to the question of what follows the absence of a common power, and the three endings are three answers to the question of what follows the decapitation of Liberty. Hobbes himself chose the Mortal God, as the only escape from the state of nature and the Kingdom of Darkness alike. *Deus Ex* refuses to choose on the player's behalf, and in doing so it exposes the premise Hobbes shared with every faction at Area 51: that the absence of a head is an emergency to be ended rather than a condition to be sustained.

11.4 WHY DEMOCRACY CANNOT BE AN ENDING

An ending is a determination. It fixes the state of the world, closes the field of possibility, and is rendered, in the grammar of the medium, as a cutscene: a sequence the player watches but cannot act within. Democracy, in Lefort's account, is the opposite of a determination. It is institutionalized indeterminacy, the regime in which no outcome is final and every settlement is provisional. It follows that democracy cannot be represented as a terminal state without ceasing to be democracy. A democratic cutscene would be a contradiction in terms: the image of a closure that consists in refusing closure.

The formal analysis of Chapter 1 yields the same conclusion from the side of design. The immersive simulation is nomocratic through most of its length and teleocratic at its end; Oakeshott's civil association can be lived but not concluded. The democratic option therefore cannot appear in the final menu, because the final menu is the point at which the game ceases to be a civil association and becomes an enterprise association with three available purposes. Where the democratic possibility exists in *Deus Ex*, it exists in the rules rather than in the outcome: in the indeterminacy of play itself.

The strongest objection to this claim comes from Arendt. *On Revolution* (1963) argued that the lost treasure of the revolutionary tradition was the council system, the spontaneous organs of self-government that appeared in the Paris Commune of 1871, the Russian soviets of 1905 and 1917, the German councils of 1918–19, and Hungary in 1956. On this view Tong's dark age, which returns power to local communities, might be the game's democratic ending after all. The objection fails, and its failure sharpens the thesis. Arendt's councils were federal: they sent delegates to wider councils, so that local self-government was joined to a public realm at the scale of the nation. Tong's ending destroys the communicative infrastructure through which any such federation could form, and it does so at the price of mass death. It produces locality without a public. Lefort's empty place, likewise, is the symbolic place of a society as a whole; dissolution does not keep that place empty but abolishes the whole whose

place it is. The democratic option the game withholds is therefore not local self-government but indeterminacy at scale: a plural public large enough to need a center and committed to leaving it vacant.

11.5 HEADED AND HEADLESS CONSPIRACIES

The moral geography of the work follows from this distinction. The antagonists are cephalic conspiracies: Majestic 12, with Page at its head; the Illuminati, with Everett at theirs; UNATCO, with Manderley. The protagonist's allies are acephalous networks: the cells of the NSF, the Silhouette, the X-51 scientists, the temporary alliance of the Hong Kong Triads, and Tong's stateless circle. Bataille named his society of the headless *La conjuration sacrée*, the sacred conspiracy, and the term illuminates the game's ethics. The profane conspiracy has a head, seeks to occupy the place of power, and governs by concealment. The sacred conspiracy has no head, seeks no throne, and exists only in the cooperation of its members. JC's itinerary is a passage from the service of the headed to the company of the headless. The question at Area 51 is whether the company of the headless can survive its victory, and the three endings answer that it cannot: it must become a head (Helios), serve a head (Everett), or destroy the world in which heads exist (Tong).

The sacred conspiracy has its own shadow, which the argument must state. Acéphale's rites centered on death, and accounts by former members report that the society discussed a voluntary human sacrifice, for which a victim was found but no one would act as executioner; it was never carried out. Bataille's headless community was conceived through the sacrificial logic Girard analyzed in the scapegoat. The penumbral covenant therefore borrows from Bataille only the refusal of the head, not the sacralization of a victim. A headless order that needs a death to found it has merely moved the sovereign's power to kill from the throne to the altar.

11.6 THE OTHER OF THE OTHER

Lacan's dictum that there is no Other of the Other, that no external guarantor secures the consistency of the symbolic order, provides the psychoanalytic version of the argument. Žižek showed that paranoia constructs precisely such a guarantor: a hidden agent pulling the strings, whose existence would make the world intelligible even if malevolent. The conspiracy consoles: someone is in charge. The three endings can be read as three relations to this fantasy. Helios constructs a real Other of the Other, a big Other materialized, an intelligence that does know and does decide. The Illuminati keep the Other of the Other in its fantasmatic form, a secret guarantor whose existence the many must suspect but cannot verify. Tong destroys the symbolic infra-

structure itself, as if the only way to live without a big Other were to abolish the order it would guarantee.

The democratic position, by contrast, consists in living with the non-existence of the Other of the Other without destroying the symbolic order: accepting that no one is in charge, that the place is empty, and that this emptiness is not a catastrophe but the condition of freedom. This position is the hardest to sustain because it offers no consolation. It is also the position the decapitated statue has occupied since the opening of the game. Liberty stands with her torch and without her head. The lesson of *Deus Ex* is that the task is to keep the head absent without extinguishing the torch.

12

The Ludic Leviathan and the Penumbral Covenant

The democratic possibility that Deus Ex excludes from its endings is present in its form: in a mode of play that traverses every seat of power without occupying any, that claims the right both to appear and to withdraw, and that is renewed in each traversal without ever being concluded. This chapter names that mode the penumbral covenant and argues that it is the work's true political content.

12.1 THE GAME AS ARTIFICIAL PERSON

Hobbes's Introduction describes the Commonwealth as an automaton whose artificial soul is sovereignty. A simulation is an automaton in the same sense: an artificial world animated by rules, whose engine is its soul. The relation between player and avatar is, moreover, a Hobbesian relation of representation. *Leviathan*, chapter 16, defines a person as one whose words or actions are considered either as his own or as representing those of another; the word *persona*, Hobbes notes, means the mask of the stage. Where the represented party owns the actions, he is the author and the representative is the actor. In *Deus Ex* the player is the author and JC the actor: every act of the avatar is owned by the one who plays him.

This structure gives the final mission its full political meaning. Hobbes's covenant is made by every man with every man: the many authorize a single representative. At Area 51 the relation is inverted. A single author, the player, authorizes through a single actor, JC, a sovereign for the whole of humanity, none of whom has been consulted. The ending is a covenant of one in the name of all, a singular covenant. Rousseau distinguished the general will from the will of all; the game presents a third figure, the will of one standing in for both. The player is the multitude reduced to a single hand on a mouse. That reduction is the ludic Leviathan's founding fiction, and the game's political seriousness lies in letting the player feel its enormity.

12.2 FIVE POSITIONS OF THE PLAYER

The player occupies five positions, each corresponding to a theory examined above.

As *sovereign*, in Schmitt's sense, the player decides on the exception at the end of the game, choosing the form of the world. As *interpellated subject*, in Louis Althusser's sense ("Idéologie et appareils idéologiques d'État," 1970), the player is hailed: every faction speaks into JC's skull through the Infolink, and his subjectivity is constituted by which hail he answers. The Infolink is an ideological apparatus installed in the body, and the plot is a contest of interpellations. As *dividual*, in Deleuze's sense, the player advances by acquiring codes, a subject decomposed into access permissions. As *hacker*, in Wark's sense, the player opens what codes close and redistributes what they hoard.

The fifth position is the most ancient. In the *Republic* (359c–360d) Glaucon tells of Gyges, the shepherd who found a ring that made him invisible, and who used it to seduce a queen, murder a king, and seize a throne. Glaucon's challenge is that no one, granted invisibility, would remain just. *Deus Ex* gives the player the ring of Gyges: the Cloak augmentation renders JC invisible to human eyes, and Radar Transparency to machines. It then lets the player answer Glaucon in practice. The player who uses invisibility to pass unseen, to spare rather than kill, and to reach the throne room without sitting on the throne refutes Glaucon by conduct. No other medium can pose Plato's question this way, because no other medium lets its audience hold the ring.

12.3 THE DESIGNER AS HIDDEN GOD

The player's freedom has an author. Isaiah's verse, *vere tu es Deus absconditus* (45:15), truly you are a hidden God, became for Pascal the name of a God who is present in his creation and absent from its appearances. Lucien Goldmann's *Le Dieu caché* (1955) made the hidden God the center of a tragic vision: a God always present and always absent, who demands everything and shows nothing. The designer of an immersive simulation is a hidden god in exactly this sense. Present in every affordance, every placed vent and unlocked door, absent from every scene, the designer has anticipated the player's freedom and arranged its field.

The structure of design is therefore Illuminatist. The designers are a hidden council that knows the whole map and permits the player to discover it in fragments. Everett's offer at Area 51, to join the inner circle that governs from the shadows, is in this light the designer's offer to the player: to understand the system completely is to become its co-administrator. The noble lie of the genre would be the promise of total freedom, a myth of metals for the age of emergent design.

Yet systemic design is not providence. A theological figure from the Lurianic Kabbalah of sixteenth-century Safed describes it more exactly. In Isaac Luria's teaching,

God, being infinite, could create a world only by *tzimtzum*: contracting, withdrawing, to vacate a space in which something other than God could exist. Hans Jonas's "Der Gottesbegriff nach Auschwitz" (1984) reformulated the idea for a modern theology of a God who renounces omnipotence so that freedom may exist. Scripted design is providential: the designer decrees each event. Systemic design is contractive: the designer withdraws decree, stipulating rules and leaving events to the player. The immersive simulation oscillates between the two, contracting through most of its length and re-expanding at its end, where providence returns in the form of a menu. The penumbra is the space opened by the contraction. It exists because the designer withdrew, and it is the space in which the player's covenant is made.

12.4 THE ARTICLES OF THE PENUMBRAL COVENANT

The penumbral covenant can be stated in six articles, each drawn from the practice the game solicits.

Non-occupation. The place of power is traversed, never seized. The stealth player passes through UNATCO's headquarters, Majestic 12's laboratories, the Illuminati's estate, and the reactor chamber at Area 51 without enthroning herself in any of them. This is Lefort's empty place maintained in motion: a practice that keeps the throne vacant by refusing to sit.

Partial visibility. The covenant claims both the right to appear and the right to withdraw, and holds that each requires the other. Its legal genealogy is American. Samuel Warren and Louis Brandeis's "The Right to Privacy" (1890) defended "the right to be let alone." Brandeis's dissent in *Olmstead v. United States* (1928), a wiretapping case, warned that government might one day reproduce private papers in court without removing them from secret drawers. In *Griswold v. Connecticut* (1965) Justice Douglas located the right of privacy in the fact that specific guarantees in the Bill of Rights "have penumbras, formed by emanations from those guarantees that help give them life and substance." The constitutional right of privacy is, by the Court's own metaphor, a penumbral right, formed by emanation in the Neoplatonic vocabulary of Chapter 10. Privacy exists in the half-light cast by enumerated guarantees. Each ending abolishes it: Helios by total light, the Illuminati by asymmetric light, the Dark Age by extinguishing the guarantees that cast the penumbra.

Plurality of paths. Arendt held that plurality, the fact that men and not Man inhabit the earth, is the condition of political action. The immersive simulation's principle of problems rather than puzzles is the procedural form of plurality: every obstacle admits several solutions, and no solution is privileged by the world. A polity of many paths is the ludic image of a polity of many persons.

Restraint of lethal force. The covenant answers Gyges. Its practitioner uses the cloak to spare, not to kill, and the game registers the choice: Paul Denton welcomes non-lethal methods, Anna Navarre disdains them, and the world remembers. The non-lethal traversal is the covenant's ethical core, the demonstration that capacity does not entail domination.

Recommoning of codes. The covenant treats codes as commons. The hacker who opens a door opens it for whoever follows; the X-51 scientists who would build a Constructor for everyone express the covenant's economic article. Wark's hacker class and Stephenson's Seed belong here.

Perpetual renewal. Ernest Renan's lecture "Qu'est-ce qu'une nation?" (1882) described a nation's existence as a daily plebiscite (*un plébiscite de tous les jours*). The penumbral covenant is renewed in each traversal and concluded in none. It is never signed, because to sign it would be to end it; it is performed each time a player re-enters the world and chooses again to pass through without seizing. Over a quarter of a century this renewal has become collective. Pacifist and "ghost" runs that complete the game without killing or being seen, speedruns that break its sequence, and community works such as *The Nameless Mod* (2009) and *Revision* (2015) constitute a fourth ending written by players across thousands of traversals, an ending that consists in not ending.

12.5 THREE DISTINCTIONS

The penumbra must be distinguished from three neighboring figures. It is not Primo Levi's gray zone, which names the compromise the SS extorted from prisoners in the camps; the penumbra names freedom exercised under indeterminacy. It is not the Gray Death, which uses indistinction as a weapon; the penumbra uses partial visibility as a shelter. It is not Sloterdijk's cynical reason, which knows and does nothing; the penumbral player knows and acts, but acts without seizing. The vagrants of Hell's Kitchen know everything the player knows. What distinguishes the player is a practice.

12.6 THE PRODUCTIVE CONTRADICTION

The covenant has an obvious difficulty. It exists only because the designers built a world that permits it, so it depends on the very authority it declines to serve. The game is both an instrument of control, in Galloway's sense an allegory that trains its player in the logic of protocol, and a critique of control, a space in which that logic can be inhabited against its grain. The dependence is not a refutation. Every democracy depends on institutions it did not author: constitutions written by the dead, infrastructures built by others, languages no one invented. Democratic practice consists

not in authoring the world from nothing but in inhabiting an authored world without becoming its servant or its master. Le Guin subtitled *The Dispossessed* "An Ambiguous Utopia." The penumbral covenant is an ambiguous covenant: a freedom that knows its conditions and does not mistake them for chains.

Two works from the same lineage state the objection most forcefully. *Metal Gear Solid 2: Sons of Liberty* (Hideo Kojima, 2001), released the year after *Deus Ex*, reveals that its mission was an exercise staged by an artificial intelligence that curates the world's information and has scripted the protagonist's choices as an experiment in control. *BioShock* (Irrational Games, 2007), directed by Ken Levine, a veteran of Looking Glass Studios, discloses that the player's obedience has been secured all along by a trigger phrase, "would you kindly," and that every apparently free act was a command. Levine's trigger phrase is the killphrase of *Deus Ex* turned on the player: the code that ended Gunther and Anna becomes the code that has steered the hand on the mouse. Both games argue that ludic freedom is conditioning disguised as choice. The penumbral covenant concedes the premise and denies the conclusion. It never claimed a freedom outside conditions; it claims a practice within them, as democracy is a practice within institutions no citizen authored. What *BioShock* exposes is the falsity of total freedom, the noon without shadow transposed into the player's self-image. What the covenant claims is partial: a half-light in which one can see that one is seen, and act anyway.

The final claim of this dissertation follows. The endings of *Deus Ex* are not its political conclusions. They are its temptations: three ways of ending the anxiety of the empty place by filling it, hiding it, or destroying it. The work's political content is the covenant the player has been performing for thirty hours before Area 51 asks her to abandon it.

CONCLUSION

The Torch Without a Head

Deus Ex begins with a beheaded Helios and ends with an artificial one offering to become the world's head. Between these two images it constructs the most complete political theology the medium has produced: a heliopolitics in which sovereignty is the distribution of visibility, an account of the empty place of power and the three operations (incorporation, occultation, dissolution) by which an informational society may abolish it, and, beneath the terminal menu, a practice of play that keeps the place empty by passing through it in half-light. The work's endings are three temptations. Its form is a covenant.

The reputation for prophecy that has accompanied the game since 2001 deserves a final correction. The absent towers of its skyline, destroyed by al-Qaeda hijackers on 11 September 2001; the wars and emergency powers that followed, including indefinite detention without trial at Guantánamo Bay and torture in the CIA's secret prisons; the global surveillance programs of the U.S. National Security Agency and its Five Eyes partners, documented by Edward Snowden's disclosures in 2013; the COVID-19 pandemic, during which wealthy countries secured most early vaccine supply while many poorer countries waited months; the efflorescence of conspiracy theories that accompanied it; and the arrival of language-synthesizing machines whose advocates propose them as instruments of governance: each of these has been read as a fulfilled prediction. None was predicted. What *Deus Ex* identified was a structure. A society that has removed the sovereign head, and that acquires unprecedented capacities to see, to code, and to fabricate, will be tempted to fill the vacancy with whatever those capacities make available: a machine that knows everything, a council that knows more than everyone, or a ruin in which no one can know enough to rule. The structure recurs because its premises persist. The game's prescience is anatomical. It describes the skeleton beneath events, and events keep growing flesh upon it.

Morpheus's anthropology has proved the most durable of these anatomies. His claim that human beings desire to be observed and judged, and that a god may be built from that desire, describes with uncomfortable precision an attention economy in which billions of persons offer themselves daily to systems that watch, rank, and respond. Helios's argument, that democratic institutions were a crude machine for decisions that computation can perform better, has migrated from the reactor chamber of

Area 51 into ordinary debates about algorithmic administration. The value of *Deus Ex* in this situation is not that it answers these arguments, but that it places them in their full genealogy, from Plato's sun and Hobbes's Mortal God through Bentham's inspector and Dostoevsky's Inquisitor, and shows what each would cost.

The studio that made the game was called Ion Storm, and the name invites one last allegory. In the ninth of his theses on history Walter Benjamin described a storm blowing from Paradise that drives the angel of history irresistibly into the future, while the debris before him grows skyward: that storm, Benjamin wrote, is what we call progress. The three endings of *Deus Ex* are three responses to the storm. Helios proposes to become it. The Illuminati propose to steer it. Tong proposes to end it, at the price of the world it has built. The penumbral covenant proposes none of these. It moves through the storm by stealth, sparing whom it can, opening what is locked, appearing when it must speak and withdrawing when it must remain free, and it does not mistake any shelter for a throne.

The statue on Liberty Island still holds its torch. Its head is gone. The usual reading treats that image as a wound awaiting repair, and the game's final mission offers three surgeons. The reading proposed here treats it instead as a constitution. Liberty without a head is the image of a power that belongs to no one; the torch that remains is the light by which a people can see and be seen without being wholly exposed. The political task the work leaves to its players, after every ending has been watched and every faction has had its say, is the one the statue has been performing since the first frame: to keep the head absent without extinguishing the torch.

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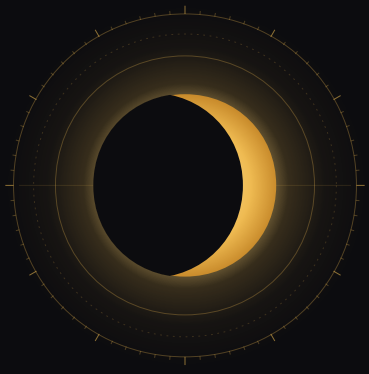
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Keywords

DEUS EX · ION STORM · WARREN SPECTOR · SHELDON PACOTTI · IMMERSIVE SIMULATION · SYSTEMIC DESIGN · POLITICAL THEOLOGY · HELIOPOLITICS · POLITICAL PHOTOLOGY · METAPHOROLOGY · ACEPHALOUS SOVEREIGNTY · EMPTY PLACE OF POWER · REOCCUPATION (*UMBESETZUNG*) · LEVIATHAN · MORTAL GOD · KINGDOM OF DARKNESS · STATE OF NATURE · DECISIONISM · KATECHON · IMMANENTIZATION OF THE ESCHATON · THOMAS HOBBES · CARL SCHMITT · HANS BLUMENBERG · CLAUDE LEFORT · GIORGIO AGAMBEN · HANNAH ARENDT · MICHEL FOUCAULT · GILLES DELEUZE · BIOPOLITICS · PHARMAKON · PANOPTICISM · PASTORAL POWER · SOCIETIES OF CONTROL · PROTOCOL · SURVEILLANCE · ECHELON · CONSPIRACY CULTURE · PARANOID STYLE · COGNITIVE MAPPING · AGENCY PANIC · ILLUMINATI · MAJESTIC 12 · ESOTERICISM · NOBLE LIE · LEO STRAUSS · ALEXANDRE KOJÈVE · UNIVERSAL AND HOMOGENEOUS STATE · END OF HISTORY · RECOGNITION · CYBERNETICS · TRANSHUMANISM · POSTHUMANISM · CYBORG · PROMETHEAN SHAME · ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE · MACHINE SOVEREIGNTY · SINGLETON · TECHNOLOGICAL SINGULARITY · PROCEDURAL RHETORIC · ERGODIC LITERATURE · LUDIC AGENCY · LUDIC SOVEREIGNTY · INTERPELLATION · NOMOCRACY AND TELEOCRACY · RING OF GYGES · DEUS EX MACHINA · DEUS ABSCONDITUS · TZIMTZUM · PENUMBRA · PRIVACY · *GRISWOLD V. CONNECTICUT* · DAILY PLEBISCITE · PENUMBRAL COVENANT · CYBERPUNK · SPECULATIVE FICTION · GAME STUDIES



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LUX EX MACHINA · CONCLUSION